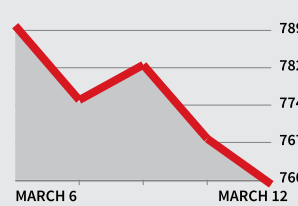


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 76034.42 (-829.29)

IN FOCUS



	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23639.15	-227.70
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.87	-0.23
US Dollar (in ₹)	92.19	+0.15
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	159662.00	+74
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	268301.00	+2291

DATA FOCUS.

Smartphones emerged the largest export category by value in 2025, marking a shift in the country's trade composition **p8**



WARNING.

Govt advisory reins in weightloss drug promotions amid competition and aggressive marketing campaigns **p9**

BENGALURU • CHENNAI • COIMBATORE • HUBBALLI • HYDERABAD • KOCHI • KOLKATA • MADURAI • MALAPPURAM • MANGALURU • MUMBAI • NOIDA • THIRUVANANTHAPURAM • TIRUCHIRAPALLI • VIJAYAWADA • VISAKHAPATNAM

Regd. TN/ARD/14/2012-2014, RNI No. 55320/94

QUICKLY.

LISTING MOVE

NSE appoints 20 merchant bankers and 8 law firms



Mumbai: The National Stock Exchange has concluded the process of selecting merchant bankers, legal advisers and other intermediaries for its proposed initial public offering. In a statement, it said the selection was carried out through a "structured, transparent and competitive process" in accordance with the framework approved by its IPO Committee. **p6**

BANKING REFORM PUSH

High-level panel may suggest CRR, SLR review

New Delhi: The proposed High-Level Committee on Banking for Viksit Bharat is likely to examine issues such as reserve ratio requirements and bank licensing to improving India's credit-to-GDP ratio and the transition framework for small finance banks and NBFCs, according to indications given to a parliamentary panel. The government is expected to announce the terms of reference (ToR) for the review committee soon. **p7**

Govt to ensure commercial units get 20% of LPG demand

RELAXATION. Tells State PCBs to allow eateries to use biomass pellets, coal, kerosene

Our Bureaus

New Delhi/Chennai/Bengaluru

Even as the fuel crisis caused by the West Asia war disrupts food services at restaurants, corporate campuses and large events across the country, Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri told the Lok Sabha on Thursday that commercial establishments will receive 20 per cent of their average monthly LPG requirement in a partial restoration of supplies.

"In a major decision, 20 per cent of the average monthly commercial LPG requirement will be allocated from today by OMCs, in coordination with the State governments, so that there is no hoarding or black marketing," Puri told Parliament.

ALTERNATIVE OPTIONS Alongside the limited supplies, the government also activated alternative fuel options to ease pressure on LPG.

State Pollution Control Boards have been advised to temporarily permit the use of biomass and RDF pellets,



BURNERS OFF. A fast-food outlet in Thiruvananthapuram displays a notice citing limited food availability due to the shortage of cooking gas

kerosene and coal by restaurants and hospitality establishments for one month.

OPERATIONAL CHANGE Even as these measures take effect, the LPG disruption is ripping through restaurants, hotels and corporate campuses with large kitchens.

According to Arshad Syed, Executive Director, Impresario Entertainment & Hospitality Pvt Ltd, which runs popular restaurant chains like SOCIAL and Smoke House Deli, the LPG disruption had impacted operations across the industry.

"Wherever possible, we are exploring operational adjustments, including electric cooking solutions, to ensure

continuity in our kitchens," he said.

At Infosys' Pune campus, an internal communication said food court vendors are receiving reduced LPG supplies under the revised government guidelines, forcing cafeterias to source cooked food from external kitchens, while vendors increased the use of electrical appliances and biofuels.

Companies including Bosch, Cisco and Tata Consultancy Services have reduced cafeteria offerings, with some serving simple fares of sandwiches, salads, curd rice and poha.

In some cases, the strain on food vendors began affecting work arrangements.

HCLTech has asked employees to work from home on March 12-13.

MENU CUTS

Institutional catering firms said they were improvising rapidly. Sanjay Kumar, CEO and MD of Rassense, which serves large manufacturing facilities, said the company is exploring alternatives such as boilers and induction cooking infrastructure while adjusting menus towards steamed foods or dropping certain items depending on the local conditions.

Corporate food service providers reduced the dishes that burn large quantities of cooking gas. The Compass Group said it will introduce "business continuity menus", cutting down on high gas-consuming items such as dosa and chapati.

The ripple effects were also felt in the events industry. Dipti Sawalka, Founder and Creative Director of Gourmet Design Company and Varak, said the LPG shortage had begun to influence how wedding caterers design menus and operate food stations.

More reports on **p2, p3**

'Shadow fleet' tankers with Russian oil divert to India after US import waiver

T E Raja Simhan

Chennai

India could see some near-term easing in crude oil supplies as several tankers carrying Russian crude, including vessels from the so-called "shadow fleet", are altering course and heading to Indian ports following a US waiver on imports from Russia.

Shadow fleets — or dark or ghost fleets — consist of tankers operating outside the conventional regulatory framework governing most global maritime traffic, often transporting sanctioned oil cargo.

Vessel-tracking data from UK-based maritime analytics firms Lloyd's List Intelligence and Vortexa indicate that at least four tankers have already diverted towards India. These include two sanctioned Aframax vessels, one sanctioned Suezmax and a non-sanctioned very large crude carrier (VLCC) that is part of the shadow fleet.

According to a Lloyd's report, the Aframax tankers *Oasis* and *Noble Walker*, which are sanctioned by the EU and the UK but not by the US, were originally bound for China after loading crude from Russia's Far East. Both vessels have since altered course.

Another vessel, the EU- and UK-sanctioned Suezmax



SILENT TRADE. Shadow fleets are tankers operating beyond the conventional regulatory framework, often transporting oil cargo under sanctions REUTERS

Indri (Sierra Leone registered with nearly 80,000-tonne capacity), was initially sailing towards Singapore before abruptly changing course on March 4. The tanker discharged crude, originating from Russia's Baltic region, at Gujarat's Sikka port on March 9.

RUSSIAN OIL AT SEA

Similarly, data from Vortexa show that about 60 million barrels of Russian crude are currently at sea, having been loaded before March 6 — the date the waiver was announced — and are within a typical 30-day sailing distance to India. Of this, around 24 million barrels are on non-sanctioned vessels, while the remaining 36 million barrels are on sanctioned tankers.

Delia He, associate freight analyst at Vortexa, said the tanker *Sarah* (Hong Kong registered with 1.6 lakh tonne capacity) may have moved

into floating storage near Singapore while awaiting a buyer before redirecting its voyage. The vessel had sailed past Sri Lanka heading east when it began drifting on March 5. It completed its turnaround on March 8 and subsequently signalled Mundra in Gujarat as its next destination.

MORE DIVERSIONS AHEAD

Industry analysts expect more such diversions in the coming weeks. "We expect to see Russian crude oil in transit or in floating storage redirected to India," said Mary Melton, senior tanker analyst at Braemar, quoted by Lloyd's List.

Braemar said it has tracked six tankers — one VLCC and five Aframax/LR2 vessels — diverting from East Asian destinations, where the cargo was originally expected to be discharged in China, and are now signalling India as their next port of call.

In a first, Liberia-flag crude carrier transits Hormuz Strait to reach Mumbai

Our Bureau

New Delhi

A foreign-flagged tanker delivered geopolitically sensitive crude oil at Mumbai on Wednesday, transiting the Strait of Hormuz, which is a first after shipping traffic turned into a trickle on the world's most critical energy choke point following the Iran war.

GOES 'DARK'

Sources said that the Liberia-flagged *Shenlong*, carrying around 1.35 lakh tonnes of Saudi Arabian crude oil, left Ras Tanura on March 1 and entered the Strait on March 8. The Suezmax switched off AIS tracking, crossing the high-risk zone and reappeared on March 9 and docked at the Mumbai port on March 11.

This is the first India-bound crude shipment to clear the Strait since the conflict began, said one of the sources. Suezmaxes are the



SMOOTH SAILING. The Liberia-flagged *Shenlong*, loaded with Saudi Arabian crude, at the Mumbai port REUTERS

largest vessels that can transit the Suez Canal, and have a capacity of 1,20,000 to 2,00,000 dwt (deadweight tonnage). A senior government official said the vessel may have transited the Strait with Iranian permission. However, this could not be immediately confirmed.

Sources also said that the *Shenlong* had started discharging the crude oil believed to have been sourced by a PSU oil marketing company (OMC). Crisil Ratings said West Asian countries account for around 30 per cent of global crude oil and about

20 per cent of liquefied natural gas (LNG) production. Much of this is transported through the Strait of Hormuz. India imports around 85 per cent of its crude oil and half its LNG requirement. Of this, 40-50 per cent of crude oil and 50-60 per cent of LNG come in via the Strait, it added.

Most vessels stopped sailing this route since March 1 due to increased risk of passage, and any prolonged disruption of this route will have a bearing on global crude oil and LNG availability, and their prices.

Retail inflation rises to 3.21% in Feb on pricey food, bullion

Shishir Sinha

New Delhi

Food and precious metals pushed up retail inflation based on the Consumer Price Index (CPI) to a 11-month high of 3.21 per cent in February, the government reported on Thursday.

Experts expect the inflation to rise further in the coming months on account of the West Asia war and the resultant fuel crisis.

This is the second print in the new CPI series with the base year of 2024.

Retail inflation was recorded at 2.74 per cent in January. The uptick in retail inflation was largely driven by higher food inflation, with major contributions from coconut, tomato and cauliflower. At the same time, prices of silver, gold/platinum jewellery rose sharply by over 160 per cent and 48 per cent, respectively, in February.

Read more on **p7**

Tariff fears back as US opens Sec 301 probe into India, 15 others over distorting 'excess capacities'

Amiti Sen

New Delhi

In an escalation of trade tensions that could raise fresh concerns for Indian exporters, the US has launched investigations into India and 15 other economies over alleged "structural excess capacity" in manufacturing that it says is distorting global markets and threatening American industries.

The move could slow negotiations on the India-US bilateral trade agreement (BTA) by increasing tariff-related uncertainty for New Delhi, sources said. Some experts caution that the probe highlights the risk of fresh tariff actions even if a trade deal is eventually concluded.

The investigation, initiated on Wednesday under Section



The move could further slow the India-US bilateral trade agreement negotiations

301 of the Trade Act of 1974, targets India's textiles, health products, construction goods, automotive goods, solar modules, petrochemicals and steel. Other economies identified by the Office of the US Trade Representative (USTR) include China, the EU, Singapore, Switzerland, Norway, Indonesia, Malaysia, Cambodia, Thailand, South Korea, Vietnam, Taiwan, Bangladesh, Mexico and Ja-

pan. "The US will no longer sacrifice its industrial base to countries exporting their excess capacity and production to us," USTR Jamieson Greer said in a statement.

TRADE SURPLUS

Greer said evidence suggests structural excess capacity in several Indian sectors. It noted that India recorded a \$58-billion bilateral trade surplus with the US in 2025 and that sectors such as textiles, health products, construction goods and automotive goods contributed to India's global goods trade surplus. The notice also flagged excess capacity in solar modules, petrochemicals and steel.

International trade expert Biswajit Dhar said the move demonstrated the futility of a trade deal with the US. "Even if we had done the trade deal

with the US, like Vietnam and Bangladesh, there was no assurance that [US President Donald] Trump would not do what he has done now," he said.

Dhar added the US may fast-track the investigations and impose Section 301 tariffs by July, as the 10 per cent global tariffs under Section 122, introduced after the US Supreme Court struck down country-specific reciprocal tariffs, are to lapse in 90 days.

Indian exporters, who saw relief when tariffs fell to 10 per cent after facing duties of up to 50 per cent since August 2025, are worried about the outcome of the probe.

Public comments open on March 17, submissions are due by April 15, and hearings begin on May 5. Consultations with affected economies have been sought, too.

Ensuring Their Smiles Plus Protection

LIC's PROTECTION Plus

Plan No.: 886 UIN: 512L361V01

Our WhatsApp No. 8976862090 Say Hi

For details, contact your Agent/Nearest LIC Branch/visit www.licindia.in

Download LIC Mobile App Visit: licindia.in Call Centre Services (022) 6827 6827

Follow us: LIC India Forever IRDAI Regn No.: 512

SALIENT FEATURES:

- Multiple Investment Fund options available to suit your needs
- Increase your Risk Cover with Top up Premium Payments
- Option to Choose Higher Sum Assured as per Age and Term
- Partial Withdrawals allowed after 5 years

A Non-Par, Linked, Life, Individual, Savings Plan

Also Available Online

भारतीय जीवन बीमा निगम LIFE INSURANCE CORPORATION OF INDIA

Har Pal Aapke Saath

BEWARE OF SPURIOUS PHONE CALLS AND FICTITIOUS / FRAUDULENT OFFERS. IRDAI or its officials do not involve in any activities of insurance business like selling insurance policies, announcing bonus or investment of premiums, refund of amounts. Policyholders or the prospects receiving such phone calls are requested to lodge a police complaint. For more details on risk factors, terms and conditions, please read sales brochure carefully before concluding a sale.

Linked insurance products are different from the traditional insurance products and are subject to the risk factors. The premium paid in linked insurance policies are subject to investment risks associated with capital markets and publicly available index. NAVs of the units may go up or down based on the performance of fund and factors influencing the capital market/publicly available index and the insured is responsible for his/her decisions. Life Insurance Corporation of India is only the name of the Life Insurance Company and Protection Plus is only the name of the linked insurance contract and does not in any way indicate the quality of the contract, its future prospects or returns. Please know the associated risks and the applicable charges, from your insurance agent or intermediary or policy document issued by the insurance company. The various funds offered under this contract are the names of the funds and do not in any way indicate the quality of these plans, their future prospects and returns.

Iran’s supreme leader vows to avenge its martyrs, keep Strait of Hormuz closed

STRONG MESSAGE. In his first address, Mojtaba Khamenei says the US must close all its bases in the region

Reuters
Dubai/Hebron

Iran will avenge the blood of its martyrs, keep the Strait of Hormuz closed and attack US bases, new Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei said on Thursday in a statement read out on state television, his first remarks since succeeding his slain father.

In the defiant address, Khamenei said the US must close all its bases in the region. The strait, which runs past Iran’s coast and supplies a fifth of the world’s oil, should remain shut to put pressure on the enemy, he said. Two tankers were ablaze in an Iraqi port on Thursday after a hit by suspected Iranian explosive-

laden boats, a step-up in attacks that have cut off oil from West Asia and defied US President Donald Trump’s claim to have won the war he launched two weeks ago.

Images verified by *Reuters* as having been filmed from the shore of the port of Basra showed ships engulfed in massive orange fireballs that lit up the night sky after the attacks, which Iraqi authorities blamed on Iranian boats. At least one crew member was killed.

THREE SHIPS HIT

Hours earlier, three other ships had been struck in the Gulf. Iran’s Revolutionary Guards claimed responsibility for at least one of those attacks, on a Thai bulk car-

rier that was set ablaze, which the Guards said had disobeyed their orders. Another container vessel reported being struck by an unknown projectile near the United Arab Emirates on Thursday. The war that began with a US-Israeli bombing campaign at the end of February has so far killed around 2,000 people and caused what the International Energy Agency describes as the biggest disruption to global energy supplies in history.

Undermining US and Israeli claims to have knocked out much of Iran’s stock of long-range weapons, more drones were reported on Thursday flying into Kuwait, Iraq, the UAE, Bahrain and Oman. Lebanon’s Iran-



TIT FOR TAT. A man holds a picture of Iran’s new supreme leader Mojtaba Khamenei while people attend a funeral ceremony for military commanders killed in strikes *REUTERS*

backed militia Hezbollah fired its biggest volley of rockets into Israel of the war, prompting fresh Israeli strikes on Beirut. Oil prices soared back above \$100 a

barrel, having come down earlier in the week when Trump said the war would be over soon. Iran has said it will not let oil through the strait until US and Israeli attacks cease. Trump repeatedly tried to calm energy markets this week by saying the surge in oil prices will be short-lived. But he has not explained how the war will end, or presented a plan to reopen the blockaded strait.

US and Israeli officials say the aim is to destroy Iran’s missile and nuclear programmes, but Trump has also demanded Iran’s unconditional surrender. “You never like to say too early you won. We won,” Trump told a rally in Hebron, Kentucky, on Wednesday. “In the first hour it was over.”

Corporate canteens tweak menus amid crisis

Our Bureaus
New Delhi/ Chennai/ Bengaluru

Corporate catering firms and institutional food services companies are redesigning food menus and working on using alternatives such as induction cooking and boilers to tide over the commercial LPG shortage crisis, triggered due to the ongoing West Asia conflict.

India Inc has also stepped in with measures including rationalising menus, with some players operating large campuses and even asking employees to work from home for some days.

Sanjay Kumar, CEO & MD, Rassense, said: “We serve nearly 350,000 meals per day with nearly 80 per cent of them made using LPG. We are looking at various alternatives such as boilers and induction cooking infrastructure wherever available at the manufacturing facilities. We are also building a buffer of LPG wherever possible and have stocks till Friday. We have also had to tweak the menus. For instance, we are offering more of steamed food items wherever boilers are available or dropping chapatis at 1-2 locations where it was being sourced from external vendors.”

Another corporate catering firm, Compass Group, said it will introduce business continuity menus, which will focus on cutting down on high gas consuming ingredients and foods. “We have rented and purchased some assets for electric cooking and in some cities we have also started to cook with bio gas,” said Ariyo Banerjee, Chief Culinary Officer, Compass India.

India Inc has also begun taking stock of the situation of the canteens and cafeterias that operate at their office premises on a daily basis. In an internal advisory sent to employees, verified by *businessline*, the company said its



own operations remain unaffected, but some of its food vendors are experiencing LPG disruptions.

In an internal mail to Infosys’s Pune employees, reviewed by *businessline*, the company said food courts will temporarily operate with limited menus. Some cooked food will be sourced from vendors’ external central kitchens, while alternative cooking through electrical appliances or biofuels will be increased.

Sources said that Bengaluru employees of Infosys were informed that food court operations would be realigned from March 12 onwards..

WORKERS & VENDORS

Raising concerns of the impact on reduced food delivery orders, the Gig Workers Association has stressed that food platforms such as Swiggy and Zomato should not penalise gig workers and ensure that their ratings and earnings are protected in such situations. “As orders are likely to slow down due to disruptions in the supply chain, they are expected to drop drastically. Since gig workers are paid on a task basis, their overall earnings could decline significantly,” it added.

Meanwhile, Hawker Joint Action Committee, an umbrella body representing the street vendors of India, on Thursday said street vendors are being forced into financial loss and environmentally damaging practices due to a crippling shortage of commercial LPG.

No shortage of fuel in TN; OMCs urge public to avoid panic buying

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Oil marketing companies have denied the shortage of petrol and diesel in Tamil Nadu, and have requested the public not to engage in panic buying of the fuel.

The OMCs, including IOCL, BPCL and HPCL, have assured the public that they are closely working with chief secretaries across States to monitor the situation.



CHOCK-A-BLOCK. The crowd outside a petrol bunk in Chennai *BUOY GHOSH*

‘ADEQUATE STOCKS’

“Indian Oil Corporation (IOC) assures the public that adequate stocks of petrol and diesel are available across Tamil Nadu, and supplies to retail outlets are continuing smoothly. All Indian

Oil petroleum terminals and supply points are well stocked with petrol and diesel to meet any demand in Tamil Nadu,” the company

said in a statement on Thursday evening.

As per IOC, M Annadurai, the State-level coordinator for the oil industry in Tamil

Nadu, has also confirmed that adequate stocks are available at all PSU petroleum terminals (IOC, BPC & HPC) across the State.

The OMCs have assured the public that they are closely working with chief secretaries across States to monitor the situation

HPCL representatives also assured *businessline* that there is no shortage of fuel in Tamil Nadu, and urged the public to avoid panic buying and hoarding of petrol.

BPCL also stressed that fears and rumours of fuel shortage in Chennai and Tamil Nadu were baseless and there was no such crisis. Long queues of motorists

could be seen outside petrol bunks across Tamil Nadu on Thursday as anxious citizens resorted to panic buying. This was partly aggravated by the news of commercial LPG shortage, buyers in fuel stations said.

The unusual surge in fuel purchases... due to panic buying in turn temporarily affected supplies at a few retail outlets, IOC said.

“Supplies to such outlets are being prioritised and the inventory position of petrol pumps is being closely monitored to ensure normal availability,” the oil major it added. Further, IOC also advised people to avoid storing petrol in plastic cans, bottles or other unapproved containers for future use considering the safety risks.

West Asia crisis may hit tyre exports: ATMA

Our Bureau
Kochi

The Automotive Tyre Manufacturers Association (ATMA) has warned that the ongoing tensions in West Asia could have serious implications for India’s tyre industry and its supply chain. It has urged the government to consider urgent policy support to address the emerging challenges.

In a representation submitted to the government, ATMA said the escalating geopolitical situation in the region could significantly disrupt tyre exports, push up raw material costs and create logistical bottlenecks for manufacturers.

According to the industry



The Association sought government support to tackle the emerging challenges

could hamper shipments not only to West Asia but also to other key markets, including Europe, the US and Africa.

COST PRESSURE

The industry is also facing cost pressures arising from the sharp volatility in crude oil prices, which is hovering around \$100 per barrel. Crude oil derivatives account for 60–70 per cent of the total raw material cost in tyre production. Several key tyre manufacturing inputs, including synthetic rubber, carbon black, processing oils and tyre cord fabrics, are derived from crude oil.

Arun Mammen, Chairman, ATMA, said: “For the Indian tyre industry, the combined impact of rising input costs, freight disruptions

and export uncertainties could affect competitiveness in international markets.”

ATMA has requested the government to consider several measures to support the industry, including reinstatement of earlier RoDTEP rates for tyres, enhancement of duty drawback rates and addressing the inverted duty structure between tyres and natural rubber, a key raw material.

The Association has also urged the government to facilitate import of natural rubber by removing import-restrictive conditions such as port restrictions on import, removing pre-import condition and restoring the export obligation period to 18 months.

Bengaluru’s Oterra hotel takes e-route

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Even as LPG supply crunch disrupts kitchens across Bengaluru’s hospitality sector, five-star hotel The Oterra has largely escaped the fallout by running its kitchens on electric induction systems.

The Electronic City-based luxury business hotel uses very little LPG in its daily operations, with most of the cooking handled by industrial induction cooktops powered by renewable energy. According to Srinivas Adiga, General Manager, The Oterra’s kitchens are functioning, dodging the LPG crunch with electric cooking. LPG usage is limited to a pizza oven and certain stewarding operations, translating to just one or two commercial cylinders a day.

“Our kitchens are fully electric, so we are largely insulated from the current LPG shortage,” said Srinivas, noting that the hotel shifted from gas-based cooking as part of a broader sustainability strategy.

3rd Regional Automation Expo in Chennai
12th to 14th March 2026, CTC, Chennai, India

THE FUTURE OF INDUSTRY STARTS HERE!

Where South India's Industries Upgrade

₹600 Cr+
PROJECTED BUSINESS POTENTIAL

23,000+
INDUSTRIAL BUYERS

20,000+
LIVE AUTOMATION SOLUTIONS

12

13

14

MARCH 2026

NEW EXHIBITION HALL, CTC, CHENNAI

LIVE DEMONSTRATIONS | LIVE DEALS | LIVE TECHNOLOGY

Robotics

Process Automation

Smart Manufacturing

SCAN QR CODE TO REGISTER

FREE ENTRY

+91-9920489667
www.south.automationindiaexpo.com

National Institute of Securities Markets
A Capacity Building Initiative of SEBI

Learn Today..

Lead Tomorrow...

Academic programs offered:

Residential programs

AICTE-approved

2-Year Full-time Program

Post Graduate Diploma in Management (Securities Markets) - PGDM(SM)

Jointly offered by NISM and MNLU Mumbai

1-Year Full-time Program

LL.M (Investment & Securities Laws)

Jointly offered by NISM and MNLU Mumbai

1-Year Full-time Program

Post Graduate Program in Investments & Securities Markets

Jointly offered by NISM and ICICI Bank

Non-Residential programs

1-Year Weekend Program | Online mode

Post Graduate Program in Financial Planning

Jointly offered by NISM and FPSB INDIA

15-Months, Weekend Program | Hybrid Mode

Post Graduate Program in Securities Market (Portfolio Management/Investment Advisory /Research Analysis)

6-Months Duration | Online Live Classes

Certificate Program in Data Science (Basic)

8-Months Duration | Online Live Classes

Certificate Program in Data Science (Advance)

10-Months | Online Live Classes

Post Graduate Certificate in FinTech

Jointly offered by NISM and NAL Academy Ltd.

Professionalizing the Securities Markets

Certifications | Training | Academics | E-learning | Investor Education

+91-82680 02412 | www.nism.ac.in

NISM Campus: Plot No. IS 1 & IS 2, Patalganga Industrial Area, Mohopada, Rasayani, Dist. Raigad, Near Navi Mumbai, Maharashtra – 410222.

Experiential Learning through

- Bloomberg Finance Lab
- Data Science Lab
- Trading Simulation Lab

Scan me for more Information

CM YK A CH-CHE

China positive

Easing FDI norms for China, a pragmatic move

As part of its multi-alignment strategy, the Centre has relaxed rules for investments from land border sharing countries — read China. The other LBCs are Bangladesh, Pakistan, Nepal, Myanmar, Bhutan, Afghanistan. Press Note 3, issued in April 2020, in the wake of the Galwan clash, was meant to prevent Chinese takeovers and acquisitions, and actively discouraged investment from Chinese entities — particularly those with a 10 per cent stake or more, situated either in LBCs or elsewhere. On Tuesday, the Centre has made some notable changes, in a bid to attract Chinese capital.



According to the modified rules, firms with a ‘non-controlling’ Chinese stake of up to 10 per cent can invest under the automatic route, with the sectoral caps applying to them. Even for those with a stake above 10 per cent, PN3 provisions have been relaxed. As opposed to being put through the rigours of ‘government approval route’, these firms may qualify for fast track nod. But to be eligible for the latter, the investment should pertain to specified sectors such as capital goods, electronic capital goods, electronic components and polysilicons and ingot wafers. The proposals may be considered fit for clearance in 60 days, if they are capital intensive and technology-heavy segments”. Majority stake will remain with Indians. It appears that a good number of Chinese investment proposals will now effectively be fast-tracked. The move is significant for geopolitical and economic reasons.

It must be analysed for the reasons underlying it and its possible effects. As for the first, the global context is truly compelling. The uncertainty unleashed by the Trump administration has forced a relook at economic and geopolitical alliances. India has been casting its net wide for quite a while in a low profile way. It relaxed professional visas and flights with respect to China late 2025. Meanwhile, US’ tariff and war tantrums have roiled India’s currency and capital flows. Chinese investment in important sectors, with Indian control over management, is certainly not a bad idea.

However, the question is whether China will invest in response to this overture. China’s investments so far in India are just about \$3 billion. For that to change, India’s manufacturing and logistics ecosystem will have to look up. Some amount of trust-building will have to happen, with both sides agreeing not to ratchet up hostilities that could translate into a sudden change of rules and regulations. India’s imports of electronic components, chemicals and other intermediaries should ideally reduce with that translating into investments here, with some technology transfer. China may want higher management control to be interested, while we need more than turnkey investment. Finally, our ties with China and Russia on the one hand, and US on the other can work as offsets, economically and geopolitically. As the adage goes, ‘there are no permanent friends or enemies, only permanent interests’.

POCKET RAVIKANTH



Indian fertilizers’ Hormuz choke

WAR PAIN. Given India’s import dependence, a prolonged war can raise fertilizer prices straining the fisc and spurring inflation



RAM SINGH

The Iran-Israel war and resultant blockage of Strait of Hormuz, a critical chokepoint handling major energy and fertilizer feedstock flows, can destabilise global fuel, fertilizers and food markets. For India, whose agricultural productivity depends heavily on imported fertilizers and energy-linked inputs, the conflict introduces serious vulnerabilities. Even if Iran facilitates uninterrupted access to India on this route, ongoing war operations have already led to rerouting of vessels, reduced ship availability, rising freight rates, refusal of insurance coverage or unaffordable high war-risk premiums and shutdown of gas terminals. These conditions complicate the movement of bulk commodities from Middle Eastern export hubs. India imported fertilizers worth nearly \$7.2 billion, accounting for 2.9 per cent of global fertilizer imports and ranking seventh worldwide, underscoring the country’s structural integration with global fertilizer markets. If the crisis prolongs, it could trigger fertilizer supply uncertainty, rising prices, larger subsidy burdens, and inflationary pressures across agriculture; therefore, it is important to decode these risks and explore the way forward.

SUPPLY-CHAIN DYNAMICS India’s fertilizer ecosystem is closely tied to global markets because domestic production is uneven across nutrient categories. While India has developed strong capacity in nitrogenous fertilizers, the country remains highly dependent on imports for phosphatic and potassic nutrients. India has highest vulnerability in Diammonium Phosphate (DAP) (see table). India is the largest importer globally, accounting for 28.7 per cent of global DAP imports. Major suppliers include Saudi Arabia (24 per cent), Morocco (22 per cent), both in critical conflict zones affecting maritime access via Hormuz and Red Sea. Any logistical disruption in these supply routes directly and adversely complicates fertilizer accessibility, availability and affordability as shipping delays and elevated freight costs can rapidly raise landed prices for Indian importers. Similarly, India imported about \$2.2

India’s fertilizers trade dynamics					
HSN code: Fertilizers	\$ (million)	Share in world imports	Rank in world Imports	Key suppliers and their export share in the world	Import dependence
Total fertilizers	7,229.2	2.9	7	—	20-25%
310530: DAP	2,800.28	28.7	1	Saudi Arabia (24%) Morocco (22%) China (27%)	40-55%
310210: Urea	2,197.59	10.8	2	Oman (15%) Russia (18%) Saudi Arabia (9.5%)	20-25%
310420: Potassium chloride	1,134.97	6.1	4	Russia (30%) Canada (37.5%)	95-100%
310520: NPK	668.13	7.7	2	Russia (32.5%)	35-45%
310230: Ammonium nitrate	167.13	5	3	Russia (36%) Georgia (4%) Bulgaria (5.6%)	15-20%
310540: Ammonium phosphate	132.12	1.7	8	China (14.3%) Russia (22.4%)	20-30%
310221: Ammonium sulphate	81.5	2	13	China (70%)	10-20%
310430: Potassium sulphate	47.48	3.8	8	Taiwan (15%)	80-90%

Source: UN Comtrade, FAI

billion worth of urea, representing 7.2 per cent of global imports and 20-25 per cent of domestic requirements. Major suppliers such as Oman (15 per cent), and Saudi Arabia (9.5 per cent) are from conflict zone raising dependence on Russia (18 per cent) and associated price pressures. Moreover, urea production depends heavily on natural gas because ammonia synthesis is energy intensive. If geopolitical tensions disrupt gas supply chains or maritime logistics in the Gulf region, the global cost of ammonia and urea production could increase sharply. Indeed, urea prices have already risen by around \$80 per tonne, tightening availability and increasing import costs. The risk extends beyond imports to domestic production as India operates more than 30 urea manufacturing plants, most of which rely on natural gas or naphtha feedstock. A considerable share of India’s liquefied natural gas imports originates in the Gulf region and prolonged disruptions in LNG shipments can significantly raise production costs for Indian fertilizer

Diversifying import sources away from the Gulf nations, securing overseas mineral resources through investments and joint ventures and raising domestic capacity is the way forward

manufacturers or reduce operational capacity. Thus, even domestically produced fertilizers remain indirectly exposed to geopolitical shocks through energy markets. Potassic fertilizers represent a major vulnerability in India’s fertilizer supply chain. Potassium chloride (MOP) shows near-total import dependence of about 95-100 per cent, with major suppliers including Russia and Canada. Similarly, NPK complex fertilizers, where imports meet nearly 35-45 per cent of domestic demand, depend heavily on imported raw materials such as phosphoric acid and potash. These patterns reveal the structural fragility of India’s fertilizer system, which remains closely tied to global trade and energy-linked supply chains. Logistics disruptions further aggravate the problem. Rising war-risk insurance premiums, vessel shortages, and rerouting of ships in Gulf waters increase freight costs and delay shipments. For bulk commodities like fertilizers, even modest increases in shipping costs can significantly raise the landed price of imports, thereby expanding India’s fertilizer import bill during prolonged geopolitical turbulence. Although India currently maintains fertilizer stocks exceeding two months of national consumption, providing a short-term buffer against immediate shortages, the principal risk lies in price escalation rather than physical scarcity. Higher international prices can increase the government’s subsidy burden and

Why is there an LPG crisis and how to tackle it

Reports of LPG shortages have triggered panic buying and suspected hoarding, further straining the available stock

bl.explainer

Richa Mishra

Why is India facing a shortage in LPG? High import dependency is a key reason for this. India imports roughly 60-62 per cent of its total LPG requirements. The surge in demand — partly due to the success of the Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana — is not being met by domestic production. The ongoing US-Israel-Iran war has disrupted supplies passing through the Strait of Hormuz. Unlike crude oil, India lacks large-scale strategic LPG reserves. Current storage capacity is estimated to last only about 22 days, which is insufficient for prolonged geopolitical disruptions.

What steps is the Centre taking to increase supply in the domestic market? The government has implemented several emergency measures to deal with the crisis and is exploring long-term structural changes too. A three-member committee of Executive Directors from three public sector oil refiners — IndianOil, Hindustan Petroleum and Bharat Petroleum — has been constituted to review allocations to restaurants, hotels and other commercial users and to

ensure fair and transparent distribution of available LPG supplies.

What are the short-term emergency measures? Short-Term emergency measures include invoking the Essential Commodities Act (ECA) to mandate all oil refineries — including private and SEZ-based units — to maximise LPG production. Refineries have been directed to stop using propane and butane for petrochemical manufacturing and instead divert these streams for the production of domestic LPG, increasing domestic production by around 28 per cent. Under the Natural Gas (Supply Regulation) Order, 2026, the government has established a four-tier priority system where household Piped Natural Gas (PNG) and LPG production receive 100 per cent assured supply, while sectors like fertilizers and power face cuts. The mandatory gap between domestic cylinder bookings has been increased from 21 to 25 days to prevent artificial scarcity and panic booking. The government is expanding the Delivery Authentication Code (DAC) system to 90 per cent of consumers to ensure cylinders aren’t illegally diverted to the commercial market by distributors.

What are the long-term measures? For the long term, it needs to work on



LPG. Emergency measures REUTERS

diversification strategies like alternative sourcing. To reduce reliance on the Strait of Hormuz, India has signed a long-term deal to import 2.2 million tonnes of LPG from the US Gulf Coast in 2026, which covers about 10 per cent of total imports. It should be noted that India was importing approximately 60 per cent of its LPG requirements from Gulf countries such as Qatar, the UAE, Saudi Arabia, and Kuwait, while 40 per cent is produced domestically. Procurement has now been actively diversified, with cargoes being secured from the US, Norway, Canada, Algeria, and Russia, in addition to available Gulf sources. Experts have recommended building dedicated underground LPG storage caverns similar to the Strategic Petroleum Reserves (SPR) for crude oil,

which could provide a 45-60 day supply buffer during wars. The Centre is encouraging a shift to e-cooking (induction stoves) and biogas to permanently lower the per-capita demand for LPG.

Do Indian companies have the capacities to produce more LPG? Indian companies do have the capacity to increase LPG production, but it is technically and economically limited. While they have recently ramped up output by 28 per cent under emergency government orders, this only covers a small fraction of the total demand. Indian refineries are currently operating at 100 per cent capacity or more. To squeeze out more LPG, they are diverting feedstock, using natural gas to extract additional LPG. These measures have increased domestic production from roughly 37,000 tonnes per day to over 46,000 tonnes per day. Refineries work by refinery design or yield limits and global market economics. Most Indian refineries are optimised to produce high-value fuels such as petrol and diesel. LPG is often a by-product of the refining process, and typical yields are only about 4-5 per cent of the total crude processed. It is difficult to significantly increase LPG without also producing more petrol and diesel, for which there may not be equivalent demand.

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Welcome move The changes approved by the Union Cabinet in the guidelines on investments from countries sharing a land border with India (LBCs) are welcome. At a time when strengthening domestic manufacturing capabilities is a national priority, the government could adopt a calibrated and flexible approach towards Chinese investments, particularly through joint ventures with Indian partners that ensure technology transfer and

domestic value creation. These policy changes are likely to encourage greater foreign direct investment (FDI), improve access to advanced technologies and deepen India’s integration with global supply chains. **M Jeyaram** Sholavandan (TN)

Oil slick This refers to ‘How persistently high oil prices could impact India’s vulnerable economy’ (March 12). As revealed in this report, India’s current

oil stocks are likely to last for 20- 25 days, a grim scenario. Notably, gas supply shortages have already begun hitting industries and consumers, with no end in sight as yet about extant Israel-US- Iran conflict. India may soon find itself on a highly slippery pitch. **SK Gupta** New Delhi

Ethanol economy Apropos the Editorial ‘Ethanol drive’ (March 12), an ethanol economy can

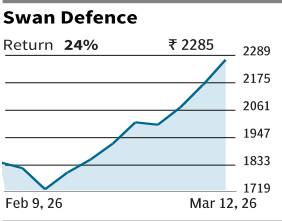
significantly reduce India’s dependence on crude oil imports while creating rural employment. Instead of relying on food crops like sugarcane, maize, or rice, agricultural waste such as crop residues, husks, and straw can be converted into ethanol. This not only prevents stubble burning and environmental damage but also provides farmers with an additional income stream. Establishing decentralized ethanol plants across rural areas would generate jobs, promote cleaner

energy, and strengthen energy security. By turning waste into wealth, India can achieve sustainable growth, reduce pollution, and empower its agricultural sector in a circular economy framework. In India, two-wheelers dominate personal transport, at present only 10 per cent ethanol blended (E10) petrol. If it is increased to E20, like in cars can have a large impact on energy security. **O Prasada Rao** Hyderabad



QUICKLY.

Swan Defence promoters to sell stake next week



Mumbai: Hazel Infra, the promoter entity of shipbuilder Swan Defence and Heavy Industries, is looking to partly sell its holding in the company through the offer for sale (OFS) route next week, people aware of the development said on Thursday. The share sale, which comes amid choppy market conditions and challenges in the shipping or maritime industry due to the Middle East conflict, will help the promoters meet the minimum public shareholding norms, they said. Investor road shows for the sale, which will see the promoter group divest about 5.01 per cent stake, have already begun, they said.

SEBI proposes to ease claim process for heir ‘securities’

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Capital markets regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has proposed sweeping changes to simplify the process for transmission of securities following the death of an investor, including raising threshold limits for simplified documentation and introducing a new fast-track mechanism for small claims.

In a consultation paper released on Thursday, SEBI said the proposals aim to reduce the procedural burden on bereaved families while ensuring safeguards against fraud and wrongful claims.

Under the proposed

Geopolitical fires singe Dalal Street; Sensex and Nifty melt around 1%

SHAKY GROUND. Auto, Bank, FMCG indices worst performers as crude prices jump over \$100/bbl during the day

Anupama Ghosh

Markets extended their losing streak on Thursday, as escalating West Asia tensions rattled investor confidence, pushing the Sensex down 829 points to close at 76,034.42 and the Nifty 50 lower by 227 points to settle at 23,639 — its lowest close in recent sessions.

Brent crude surged to over \$100 during early Asian hours but declined later, making investors nervous, impacting several sectors.

Auto was the worst-hit sector for a second consecutive session, falling over 3 per cent, dragged by M&M (down 4.39 per cent), Eicher Motors (down 3.92 per cent), Maruti Suzuki (down

3.72 per cent), and Tata Motors (down 3.30 per cent). Bajaj Finance also declined 3.44 per cent.

The Bank Nifty closed 1.1 per cent lower at 55,100. Nifty FMCG and Nifty Realty also fell 1.63 per cent and 1.60 per cent respectively. In the broader market, the Nifty Midcap 100 slipped 0.3 per cent and the Smallcap 100 declined 0.6 per cent.

On the BSE, out of 4,404 stocks traded, 2,645 declined against 1,598 advances, and 378 stocks touched 52-week lows. Ajit Mishra, SVP Research at Religare Broking, pointed out that “the lack of de-escalation signs in West Asia geopolitical tensions continued to unsettle global markets and push crude oil prices higher... raising concerns over inflationary pres-



ROUGH ROAD. The auto sector was the worst-hit for a second consecutive session, dragged by Mahindra & Mahindra (down 4.39%) and Eicher Motors (down 3.92%)

sures, currency weakness and the potential impact on India's trade balance.”

SOLE BRIGHT SPOT

Energy was the sole bright spot, gaining 1.93 per cent, with Coal India surging 5.20 per cent, NTPC rising 2.91

per cent and Power Grid advancing 1.74 per cent to ₹304. Tech Mahindra added 1.49 per cent and Jio Financial gained 1.38 per cent.

The geopolitical overhang extended beyond markets. Satish Kumar, MD and Head at InCred Research Services,

flagged that “war disruptions are slowing the movement of critical cargo” and that pharmaceutical companies dependent on imported APIs face mounting logistics challenges that could “eventually reflect in pricing pressures across the supply chain.”

Shrikant Chouhan of Kotak Securities sees 23,850 as the critical trend-decider level for day traders.

With geopolitical tensions unresolved, crude elevated and the rupee at record lows, market participants are advised to keep position sizes in check and remain nimble heading into next week, which Akshay Chinchalkar, Managing Partner and Head of Markets Strategy at The Wealth Company, identified as a “critical” window for a potential directional turn.

NSE appoints 20 bankers, 8 law firms for proposed IPO

Akshata Gorde

The National Stock Exchange (NSE) has concluded the process of selecting merchant bankers, legal advisers and other intermediaries for its proposed initial public offering (IPO), marking a key step toward the long-awaited listing of India's largest stock exchange.

In a statement on Thursday, the exchange said the selection was carried out through a “structured, transparent and competitive process” in accordance with the framework approved by its IPO Committee.

The exchange has appointed 20 merchant bankers for the issue, including Kotak Mahindra Capital Company, JM Financial, Axis Capital, ICICI Securities, SBI Capital Markets, Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors, IIFL Capital Services, Nuvama Wealth Management and HDFC Bank.

Global investment banks such as Morgan Stanley, Citigroup, JP Morgan and HSBC Securities are also part of the syndicate.

Eight law firms have been selected to advise on the transaction, including Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas, Khaitan & Co, AZB & Partners, Trilegal, Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co and international firms Latham & Watkins and Sidley Austin.

Other intermediaries engaged for the IPO include MUFG Intime India, Makarand M Joshi & Company, Manian & Rao, RBSA Advisors, Concept Communication and Redseer Strategy Consultants.

7 investment banks quoted a symbolic fee of ₹1 to secure IPO mandate from the NSE, sources said

concluded, NSE added.

The exchange's IPO has been among the most closely watched that has faced multiple delays over the past decade due to regulatory issues.

People familiar with the development said the IPO could be in the region of about ₹23,000-25,000 crore, based on the prevailing unlisted market valuation of the exchange, and is expected to be entirely an offer for sale by existing shareholders.

The intense competition for a role in the high-profile listing has also pushed fees sharply lower, with around seven investment banks quoting a symbolic fee of ₹1 to secure a mandate for the issue, sources said.

The NSE first filed the draft IPO papers with the Securities and Exchange Board of India in 2016, but the listing was stalled following investigations into the alleged co-location case, where some brokers were accused of receiving preferential access to the exchange's trading systems.

The controversy led to regulatory scrutiny and penalties, delaying the exchange's public debut for years. In recent years, the NSE has moved to settle related cases with the regulator and address governance concerns, clearing the way for the listing process to resume.

SEBI granted the exchange a no-objection certificate earlier this year, allowing it to formally begin preparations for the IPO.

NSE adds 3.56 lakh active investors in Feb

Our Bureau

Retail participation in the equity markets appears to be reviving after a brief slowdown, with the number of active investors on the National Stock Exchange (NSE) increasing for the second consecutive month in February, likely from the market correction amid geopolitical tensions.

Active investors on the exchange rose by 3.56 lakh in February, higher than the three lakh increase recorded in January, according to exchange data. The NSE considers investors active if they have traded at least once in the past 12 months.



Market participants say the uptick may partly reflect investors returning during the recent market correction, as well as the longer-term shift in India from traditional savings to market-linked investments.

“The spectacular bull-run after the Covid crash attracted lots of investors into the market and the total number

of unique investors shot up from around 30 million in April 2020 to around 130 million now. The young generation prefers investing in the market rather than depositing money in bank FDs,” said VK Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist at Geojit Investments. After a moderation last year, retail participation seems to be reviving possibly due to the recent market correction, he added.

GROWW LEADS

A significant portion of the February increase was driven by discount brokerage Groww, which added about 2.66 lakh active clients, accounting for nearly three-fourths of the total additions among discount brokers.

Other major brokerages saw relatively modest increases. Zerodha and Angel One added around 10,000 active investors each in February. Among full-service brokers, ICICI Securities added 29,830 investors, taking its total active investor base to 20.75 lakh. Meanwhile, Upstox reported a decline of about 27,535 clients, while HDFC Securities saw its active client base fall by around 14,276 in February.

Over a longer period, however, some brokerages have seen declines in active investor counts. Zerodha's active client base has fallen by about 11 lakh over the past year, while Angel One's active investor base declined by around 10 lakh in 2025.

Power stocks surge as West Asia crisis reshapes India's energy mix

Anupama Ghosh

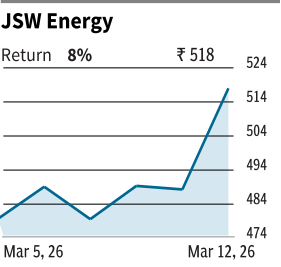
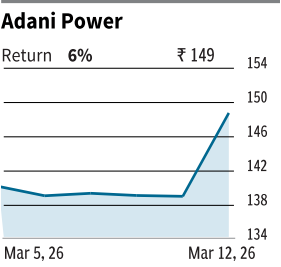
Nifty Energy closed at 36,834.35 on Thursday, gaining 695.85 points or 1.93 per cent, making it the top-performing sectoral index on a day when benchmark indices ended deep in the red.

The Sensex fell 1.08 per cent to 76,034.42 and the Nifty 50 dropped 0.95 per cent to 23,639.15 amid escalating West Asia tensions following attacks on three vessels in the Strait of Hormuz on March 11.

Within the energy index, power generation stocks led gains. Adani Power rose 7.89 per cent, ATGL gained 7.51 per cent, JSW Energy climbed 6.35 per cent, and NTPC added 2.91 per cent. BHEL and Tata Power also posted gains of 4.71 per cent and 4.20 per cent respectively.

The advance-decline ratio within the index stood at 28-12 in favour of gainers.

The rally was driven by two converging factors. First, analysts expect stronger electricity demand as forecasters predict an



early summer. Second, consumer data pointed to a rapid shift away from LPG toward electric cooking alternatives. Bigbasket's chief buying officer Seshu Kumar Tirumala said induction cooktops recorded a 5x demand spike on March 10 and a 30x spike on March 11, with the rest of kitchen appliances growing within 10 per cent of normal levels.

SUPPLY CRUNCH

The shift reflects the severity of India's LPG supply crunch.

According to a JM Financial note dated March 11, approximately 54 per cent of India's LPG requirements — those transiting the Strait of Hormuz — are currently disrupted.

Total LPG availability

stands at only 56 per cent of demand. The government has diverted all domestic LPG production to the household segment and set up a panel to manage commercial LPG allocation.

Commercial kitchens, which hold only one to seven days of cylinder inventory, face near-term disruption.

A Motilal Oswal note flagged risk to food delivery platforms Zomato and Swiggy, whose GOV growth had been accelerating through recent quarters, if restaurant operations are curtailed.

Brent crude was trading around \$97 per barrel, up approximately 25 per cent month-to-date, while diesel cracks expanded sharply, rising 65 per cent in the same period.

GSP Crop Science IPO opens on Monday at ₹304-320 price band

Our Bureau

Promoters of Ahmedabad-based GSP Crop Science are looking to dilute their holding to around an estimated 74 per cent from about 98 per cent through the company's upcoming initial public offering (IPO), while the agro-chemical manufacturer plans to use roughly ₹170 crore — nearly 70 per cent of the ₹240-crore fresh issue — to repay debt and strengthen its balance sheet.

The IPO, which will open on March 16 and close on March 18, has a price band of ₹304-320 per share.

The issue comprises a fresh issue of up to ₹240



Bhavesh Shah, CMD, GSP Crop Science

According to the company's prospectus, GSP Crop Science had total outstanding debt of around ₹478 crore as of December 2025.

BROKER'S CALL.

Choice Institutional Equities

BHARAT DYNAMICS (BUY)

Target: ₹1,965
CMP: ₹1,349.65

Bharat Dynamics (BDL) reported a weak Q3FY26; revenue declined 31.4 per cent year on year, mainly due to execution slippages. We do not view the softness as reflective of demand or competitive positioning. The weak quarter is timing-driven rather than structural, reflecting the inherently lumpy nature of missile manufacturing.

There was no cancellation or reduction in scope of orders; execution was deferred rather than lost. BDL remains firmly embedded in India's missile modernisation roadmap, with multiple high-value indigenous programmes at advanced stages of finalisation and expected to enter serial production over the next few quarters. As execution normalises, we expect a sharp improvement in revenue visibility and margin recovery, supported by ready infrastructure and proven execution capabilities. We believe that BDL's long-term investment case remains firmly intact. The company is supported by a structurally strong missile demand outlook, a robust order-book of about 8x FY25 revenue and an incremental opportunity pipeline of ₹20,000 crore, providing multi-year earnings visibility. While near-term earnings volatility may persist due to delivery phasing, we expect FY27-28E to mark a more stable execution phase, translating into improved revenue and margin normalisation.

Given BDL's strategic relevance, deep programme pipeline and long runway of indigenous missile production, we maintain our Buy rating with a target price of ₹1,965.

InCred Equities

EZE NETWORKS (ADD)

Target: ₹3,245
CMP: ₹2,342.70

The Artificial Intelligence (AI) revolution, the most disruptive shift, could start a new cloud infrastructure era with a generational opportunity to build AI-cloud platforms, including infrastructure and integrated software, and drive a over \$1.8 trillion market opportunity by 2030F/32F driven by a combination of demand and supply side factors. The non-discretionary nature of spending implies a durable investment cycle.

EZE Cloud has emerged as one of the top-tier cloud GPU infrastructure provider with a comprehensive line-up, a battle-tested software (TIR) and balance sheet (B/S) strength and parentage post equity infusion by Larsen & Toubro and is trusted by researchers, start-ups and enterprises given price performance and scalability, predictable and affordable pricing, and open-source technology build.

EZE, a springboard in the CPU era to launch many of the India-based unicorns, could be an appropriate vehicle to participate in this trilecta of opportunity. Initiate coverage with an Add rating and a target price of ₹3,245 We model revenue/EBITDA CAGR of about 60 per cent over FY25-28F driven by monetization of capacity addition and accelerating adoption. Early mover advantage in an industry with structural & secular growth drivers provide growth visibility while deterioration in GPU pricing is a key downside risk.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

TODAY'S PICK.

Jindal Saw (₹199.25): BUY

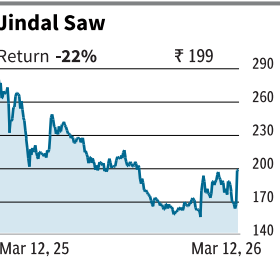
Akhil Nallamuthu

bl. research bureau

The stock of Jindal Saw has been trading with a positive bias since the beginning of this year. Since January, it has seen two sharp price rises. First, on the back of the support at ₹155 during the third week of January and now, it has gained nearly 20 per cent so far this week.

The price action shows the formation of a higher high, and the price is now above both 21- and 50-day moving averages. The prevailing price action shows strong upward momentum and the chances of a further rally are high.

Therefore, traders can



consider buying now at ₹199 and accumulating at ₹182. Place stop-loss at ₹170. When the stock rises to ₹220, revise the stop-loss to ₹205. On a rally to ₹235, raise the stop-loss to ₹225. Exit at ₹250.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

23718 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
23650	23500	23900	24200	Trade along the direction of the break of 23650-23900 range.

₹832 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
820	800	850	870	Broader trend is bearish; go short at 850 with stop-loss at 870.

₹1265 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1260	1230	1280	1300	Sell the stock if it slips below 1260; stop-loss can be 1280.

₹303 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
300	295	308	310	Go short on the stock now and on a rise to 308; stop-loss at 312.

₹270 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
267	265	275	280	Stock is hovering near a support; buy with stop-loss at 265.

₹1391 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1385	1350	1430	1470	Intraday trend is uncertain for the stock; so stay away.

₹1085 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1070	1050	1120	1150	Go long if the stock surpasses 1100; place stop-loss at 1080.

₹2442 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2420	2400	2480	2500	Price action shows steady decline; sell with stop-loss at 2480.

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 227.70 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Coal India	470.10	11.63	9.74	0.99	
NTPC	390.55	11.08	15.25	1.72	
PowerGrid Corp	303.60	4.77	18.19	1.28	
Hindalco	989.75	3.38	13.55	1.30	
Reliance Ind	1392.20	2.96	19.27	8.72	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	242.20	2.52	95.88	0.74	
Tech Mahindra	1349.80	2.14	28.80	0.80	
HCL Tech	1358.10	1.81	22.38	1.33	
Adani Enter	2002.00	1.56	16.35	0.48	
Wipro	202.51	0.18	72.17	0.54	
SBI Life	1939.40	0.08	78.45	0.81	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1031.70	0.00	21.22	1.34	
Sun Pharma	1825.30	-0.14	39.98	1.79	
ONGC	270.55	-0.17	7.57	0.98	
Bharat Elec	453.55	-0.43	55.60	1.51	
HDFC Life	645.70	-0.52	73.71	0.64	
Cipla	1234.30	-0.64	23.60	0.69	
Dr Reddys Lab	1319.00	-0.87	19.93	0.75	
Titan	4129.60	-0.97	76.92	1.58	
Asian Paints	2221.20	-1.07	54.49	0.93	
JSW Steel	1172.60	-1.28	36.92	1.02	
Max Healthcare	1020.40	-1.93	69.94	0.70	
NestleIndia	1220.80	-2.03	72.17	0.41	
TataConsumerProduct	1057.80	-2.23	71.13	0.64	
Tata Steel	193.47	-2.30	26.48	1.48	
Apollo Hosp	7574.50	-2.47	58.37	0.72	
Bajaj Finserv	1770.80	-3.07	14.74	0.94	
Adani Ports	1391.50	-3.12	25.65	0.95	
Bharti Airtel	1801.30	-3.48	27.72	0.46	
Bajaj Auto	9162.00	-4.03	28.80	0.91	
HDFC Bank	832.75	-4.03	16.55	11.82	
Eternalmt	221.17	-4.15	923.97	1.47	
Trent Ltd.	3533.60	-4.57	77.55	0.73	
Hind Unilever	2136.90	-4.77	49.93	1.76	
IntiGlobeAri	4251.70	-4.91	51.19	0.89	
Tata Motors PV	439.55	-4.93	44.14	0.43	
TCS	2442.40	-5.04	18.42	2.31	
Grasim Ind	2673.10	-5.24	19.21	0.95	
State Bank	1085.20	-5.37	11.58	4.18	
Infosys	1265.80	-8.07	38.33	4.11	
Eicher Motors	6975.50	-8.39	35.71	0.89	
UltraTech Cement	1189.60	-9.73	42.64	1.22	
ITC	304.10	-10.36	18.40	2.72	
Kotak Bank	375.30	-10.74	19.86	2.56	
Axis Bank	1234.50	-13.39	14.51	3.28	
Maruti Suzuki	13011.00	-13.99	27.40	1.58	
Bajaj Finance	863.10	-17.79	29.31	2.13	
M&M	3031.20	-26.83	22.30	2.51	
L&T	2719.50	-20.74	26.96	4.05	
ICI Bank	1266.50	-44.03	16.00	8.40	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers

▼ 74.10 pts.

	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
Adani Power	149.11	121.44	25.45	2.66
Tata Power	402.15	82.63	25.66	3.05
JSW Energy	518.30	48.78	34.80	1.26
Jindal Steel	1225.00	-42.60	61.98	2.01
Power Finance	415.90	39.32	4.11	2.74
Rural Elec	343.50	39.16	5.25	1.94
Gail (India)	152.35	35.45	11.64	1.86
Cg Power & Ind Sol	737.30	22.66	104.66	2.29
Abb India	6409.00	20.30	80.53	1.52
Linnindtree	4323.60	16.94	77.14	1.81
Adanigreenenergy	866.55	15.54	76.91	1.20
Siemens	3324.70	13.92	74.68	1.33
Adani Energy Solutions	1004.40	12.91	50.62	1.57
Canara Bank	140.34	9.41	6.91	2.14
Punjab Natl Bank	116.61	7.97	7.50	1.82
Bpcl	526.25	7.56	5.75	2.86
Hindustaneronautics	4013.50	4.78	30.17	3.44
Torrent Pharma	4446.00	4.64	66.23	2.10
Avenuesuper	3953.60	3.89	89.82	2.63
Indian Railway Finance Corp	99.92	3.59	18.64	0.81
Indian Hotels Co.	624.95	2.37	41.10	2.48
Maazgaon Dock	2443.30	1.64	40.95	0.84
Solar Industries	14525.00	0.73	86.09	1.60
Bajaj Housing Finance	83.68	-0.17	28.14	0.35
Bank Of Baroda	289.20	-0.56	7.61	2.42
Info Edge I	955.40	-1.28	36.77	1.68
Zyduslisciences	916.90	-3.64	18.36	1.94
Lic	796.35	-3.83	9.50	0.80
Indian Oilcorp	160.16	-5.27	6.13	2.70
Hindust Zinc	583.00	-5.98	20.87	1.14
Havells	1354.00	-8.70	57.27	1.54
Capgemini Devlopers	1387.40	-9.58	25.92	1.50
Three Cement	23500.00	-9.63	47.21	1.42
Vedanta	7116.90	-9.92	16.98	5.51
Bosch	31305.00	-10.67	33.49	1.23
Hyundai Motor India	1994.70	-10.78	33.79	2.03
Lic Lombard GIC	1855.30	-14.45	23.78	2.08
Pitdindt	1387.40	-14.91	61.02	1.61
Sarnvardtohosenternational	120.17	-16.26	34.85	2.41
United Spirits	1363.50	-16.48	57.66	1.82
Siemens Energy India	2866.90	-20.14	86.43	1.15
Amulbaj Cements	446.45	-20.77	22.42	1.23
Divis Lab	6282.00	-26.88	67.27	1.61
DL	120.17	-29.05	31.26	2.62
CholamandalamInGFI	1526.19	-32.72	26.57	2.92
Godrej Consumer	1052.30	-47.20	59.11	1.91
Britannia Ind	5787.00	-47.59	57.68	3.08
Bajaj Holdings	9789.00	-50.40	12.16	1.91
Varad Beraps	82.94	-54.55	52.25	2.54
Two Motor Cmp	3422.00	-125.53	43.25	3.60

Pts: Impact on index movement

QUICKLY.

Novelis to raise \$225m through municipal bonds



Mumbai: Novelis Inc, the wholly-owned US subsidiary of Hindalco Industries, has entered into a material definitive agreement to raise \$225 million through municipal bond offering and has filed a Form 8-K disclosure with the US Securities and Exchange Commission. The aluminium major said Novelis filed the Form 8-K in connection with the municipal bond issuance documentation. Such filings are used in the US to disclose financing arrangements and contractual obligations. As per the exchange notification, the filing relates to the municipal bond offering amounting to \$225 million. **OUR BUREAU**

SIB enables EPF payments on net banking platform



Mumbai: South Indian Bank (SIB) on Thursday launched Employees' Provident Fund (EPF) payment services through its Internet banking platform SIBerNet in partnership with the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO). The move allows employers and establishments to remit EPF contributions, dues and related charges directly through the EPFO portal using SIB's net banking interface. Employers can now initiate remittances without leaving the EPFO portal, using SIBerNet as the payment gateway. **OUR BUREAU**

Retail inflation rises to 3.21% in Feb on pricey food, bullion

WAR AFTERSHOCK. Consumer price inflation seen rising due to the fuel crisis

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Food and precious metals pushed up retail inflation based on the consumer price index (CPI) to an 11-month high 3.21 per cent in February, the government reported on Thursday.

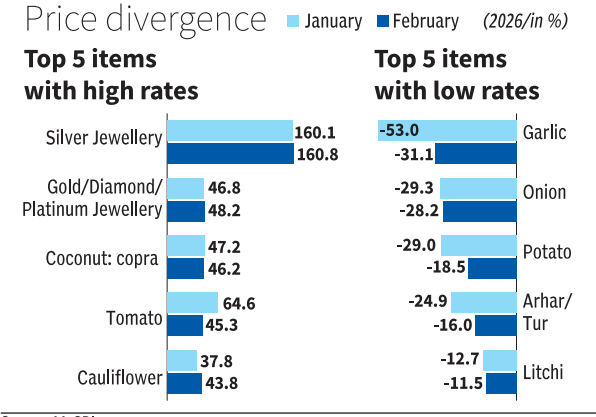
Experts expect the inflation to rise further in the coming months on account of the West Asia war and the resultant fuel crisis.

This is the second print in the new CPI series with the base year of 2024.

Retail inflation was recorded at 2.74 per cent in January.

HIGH FOOD INFLATION
The uptick in retail inflation was largely driven by higher food inflation, with major contributions from coconut, tomato and cauliflower.

At the same time, prices of silver, gold/platinum jewellery rose sharply by over



160 per cent and 48 per cent respectively in February.

According to Vikrant Chaturvedi, Associate Director (Research) at Brickwork Ratings, core inflation, excluding food and energy, is estimated to be near 3.4 per cent, signalling contained demand-side pressures in housing, health and communication.

All eyes are now on the

Gulf war and its impact on the retail inflation.

PETROLEUM COSTS
DK Pant, Chief Economist at India Ratings, noted that despite the rising crude and petroleum costs, prices at the pump have remained stable and are expected to stay that way in the near term. LPG prices have increased

by ₹60/cylinder, though.

"Factoring in the continuing increase in food product prices/inflation in March, the LPG price hike and the evolving currency movement, India Ratings expects March retail inflation to rise to 3.7 per cent," he said, adding the RBI will remain vigilant, likely maintaining a prolonged pause on policy rates.

OTHER HEADWINDS
There are some other risks. "A higher probability of an El Nino weather event in FY27 could adversely impact food inflation. Given these risks, it will be important to closely monitor the trajectory of geopolitical tensions in West Asia and the weather events. To support the kharif sowing, the government will continue to ensure fertilizer affordability and availability, despite the impact of the West Asia conflict," said Rajni Sinha, Chief Economist with CareEdge.

Rupee recovers from new intraday low of 92.36/\$ on RBI intervention

Our Bureau
Mumbai



The rupee continues to be weighed down by the intensifying West Asia war, its debilitating impact on crude oil prices and FPI-related outflows from the domestic equity markets. It sank to a new record intra-day low on Thursday, before pulling back on apparent Reserve Bank of India (RBI) intervention.

The Indian currency, which touched a record intra-day low of 92.3675 per US dollar, closed at 92.19, down 15 paise over the previous close of 92.04.

The Indian unit opened almost 25 paise weaker over the previous close, and tested an intra-day high/low of 92.07/92.3675.

The International Energy Agency has cautioned that the war in West Asia is creating the largest supply disruption in the history of the global oil market.

"With crude and oil product flows through the Strait of Hormuz plunging from around 20 million barrels/day (mb/d) before the war to a trickle currently, limited capacity available to bypass the crucial waterway, and storage filling up, Gulf countries have cut total oil production by at least 10 mb/d. In the absence of a rapid resumption of shipping flows, supply losses are set to increase," the agency said.

SELLING PRESSURE
The domestic equity markets came under selling pressure, with the BSE Sensex and Nifty 50 on Thursday closing at 1.08 per cent (or down 829.29 points) and 0.95 per cent (or down 227.70 points).

Dilip Parmar, Senior Research Analyst, HDFC Securities, said after stumbling to a historic low, the rupee re-

couped some ground, anchored by central bank support and a pullback in oil benchmarks. Though the rupee stabilised, the overarching momentum stays skewed to the downside. Parmar assessed that the spot dollar-rupee has resistance near 92.50, with downside protection hovering at 91.60.

V K Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist, Geojit Investments, said: "The rupee has been weakening since the start of the conflict in West Asia. Rising crude prices is the principal reason for rupee's weakness." He underscored that the weakness is exacerbated by sustained selling by FIIs.

Vijayakumar observed that when the FIIs turned buyers in February, there was some hope that the rupee will stabilise. But the war, the sharp spike in crude and the continuing uncertainty has belied that hope.

RBI's intervention in the market is providing some support to the rupee. But the ongoing weakness in the currency will end only when crude price declines significantly, he added.

High-level panel on banking may suggest review of CRR, SLR, licensing norms

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The proposed High-Level Committee on Banking for Viksit Bharat is likely to examine issues ranging from reserve ratio requirements and bank licensing to improving India's credit-to-GDP ratio and the transition framework for small finance banks and NBFCs, according to indications given to a Parliamentary panel.

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in her Budget speech had proposed setting up the committee to comprehensively review the

banking sector and align it with India's next phase of growth while safeguarding financial stability, financial inclusion and consumer protection. The government is expected to announce the terms of reference (ToR) for the committee soon.

Some indication of the possible scope emerged from a report of the Standing Committee on Finance tabled in the Lok Sabha on Thursday.

FINANCIAL REFORMS
According to the report, Financial Services Secretary M Nagaraju told the panel in his oral submission that the last

two high-level committees on banking were set up in 1991 and 1998. Chaired by M Narasimham, those panels made recommendations that led to major financial sector reforms.

Explaining the rationale for a fresh review, Nagaraju said bank-led credit growth had been the strategy followed by most developing economies that later became developed.

Taking note of a member's observation that India's credit-to-GDP ratio stands at about 57 per cent, he said: "We are among one of the lowest."

Highlighting the need to



M Nagaraju, Secretary, Financial Services

Therefore, we need to take a look at this. That is the one point," he said.

SIGNIFICANT CHANGES
He also noted that the regulatory architecture has undergone significant changes over the past three decades and requires a comprehensive review.

Another area that could come under scrutiny is the statutory reserve requirements maintained by banks. Currently, banks must keep a portion of their deposits as reserves through instruments such as the cash reserve ratio (CRR) and the statutory liquidity ratio

(SLR). "Almost 21 per cent of the total capital of the bank is kept in reserves in different forms. This means that for every ₹100, they can lend the rest of the amount, but ₹21 has to be kept as capital for different instruments such as SLR and CRR. Do we need to maintain these ratios? That is also a consideration," he said. The committee may also look at licensing norms for banks. Nagaraju noted that over the past decade, the Reserve Bank of India has issued a banking licence to only one entity.

However, he indicated that more players may be needed to support credit ex-

pansion. "Credit growth cannot happen on its own, in a vacuum. Thus, there are several issues involved in this," he said.

FUTURE TRAJECTORY
The panel could also examine ownership structures and the future trajectory of smaller financial institutions. "Regarding bank ownership, how do we transition or graduate small finance banks? How do we look at NBFCs? These are all inter-related issues. Therefore, we wanted a high-level committee to review this and suggest actionable steps for the government," he said.

Honda warns of \$15.7 b charge on global EV downturn

Bloomberg

Honda Motor faces up to ¥2.5 trillion (\$15.7 billion) in charges and an historic annual loss as it joins a growing list of global brands battered by the rapid unravelling of the electric vehicle transition.

The carmaker's strategy rethink will see it cancel the development and launch of three EV models that had been planned for North America, the company said on Thursday.

OPERATING LOSS

Honda also forecast between ¥270 billion and ¥570 billion in operating losses for the fiscal year ending in March.

Meanwhile, its net loss could be as much as ¥690 bil-



BIG AMBITIONS. Honda forecast operating losses between ¥270 billion and ¥570 billion for the fiscal year ending March

lion — the first since Honda began disclosing consolidated results in 1977.

It previously predicted a profit.

"The situation changed far more rapidly than we expected," Chief Executive Officer Toshihiro Mibe said.

"The suspension of EV subsidies in North America undercut growth, and competition in China meant we couldn't provide attractive models or maintain our competitive edge."

Just last month Honda warned of surging expenses

related to its EV business, but the shock announcement lays bare how fast electric ambitions are crumbling.

After piling into the sector as clean-energy initiatives fuelled a bullish outlook, carmakers are now scaling back their big EV bets as they struggle with volatile demand and intense competition from Chinese manufacturers.

EV STRATEGY

Honda's charges would put it alongside Stellantis NV, which is taking more than €22 billion (\$25 billion) in charges mainly linked to reversing course in its EV strategy, and Ford Motor Co's \$19.5 billion hit from its overhaul.

Honda's ¥2.5 trillion hit will be split almost evenly

across this fiscal year and the next, it said.

FINANCIAL FALLOUT

The financial fallout is relatively large because Honda had been particularly aggressive on EVs, according to Bloomberg Intelligence senior auto analyst Tatsuo Yoshida.

"The scale of the charges exceeded expectations and are likely to be viewed negatively in the near term," he said.

"Uncertainty and risks remain, so it is too early to say that all negative factors have been cleared. Nevertheless, the disclosure clarifies a substantial portion of the downside related to BEVs, offering at least some visibility where there had previously been little."

Bank of Baroda taps Asian investors for \$500 m loan

Our Bureau
Mumbai



Bank of Baroda raised a \$500 million five-year syndicated term loan on Thursday, marking its return to the global syndicated loan market after a one-year absence. The facility was arranged through the bank's IFSC Banking Unit in GIFT City, with MUFG Bank and HSBC acting as mandated lead arrangers, underwriters and bookrunners.

The deal drew participation from 13 investors across Taiwan, South Korea, Japan and Singapore. The bank said the proceeds will be used for general banking and corporate purposes.

INVESTOR CONFIDENCE

Managing Director and CEO Debadatta Chand said the transaction reflects global investor confidence in the bank's financial management and supports its strategy of diversifying funding sources.

The deal continues the

bank's push to expand its international investor base beyond its traditional domestic one. Bank of Baroda currently holds investment-grade credit ratings from all three major agencies — BBB with a stable outlook from S&P Global Ratings, BBB- with a stable outlook from Fitch (which recently upgraded its viability rating), and Baa3 with a stable outlook from Moody's.

Bank of Baroda is a majority government-owned lender with operations in 15 countries. As of December 31, 2025, its total international business stood at ₹4,879.08 billion, accounting for 16.08 per cent of its global business.

TVS unveils battery-as-a-service across EV range

Our Bureau
Chennai

TVS Motor Company (TVSM) has introduced battery-as-a-service (BaaS) across its EV portfolio, offering customers a new and flexible ownership model.

It has strengthened its electric vehicle portfolio with the launch of TVS Orbiter V1 with 1.8 kWh.

With the addition of TVS Orbiter V1 and the introduction of battery-as-a-service, TVS Motor's EV scooter range now starts at ₹49,999 (ex-showroom Delhi, inclusive of PM e-Drive).

The BaaS model lowers the upfront cost, while offering customers long-term battery assurance and peace of mind.

Customers who prefers the TVS Orbiter V1 without BaaS, can purchase it at ₹84,500 (ex-showroom Delhi, inclusive of PM e-Drive), says a release.

OWNERSHIP MINDSET

TVS Motor has introduced BaaS across its EV portfolio, enabling customers to sub-



OWNERSHIP FLEXIBILITY. Aniruddha Haldar, Senior VP–Head, Commuter & EV Business and Head, Corporate Brand & Media, TVS Motor Company, at the launch of the TVS Orbiter V1

scribe to battery usage instead of paying the full battery cost upfront.

This model separates the vehicle price from the battery cost, helping customers better understand both the upfront purchase and the ongoing running cost of an EV.

By introducing BaaS across the portfolio, TVS Motor is enabling greater

flexibility in EV ownership while expanding accessibility for a wider set of customers, says the company.

TVS Motor offers a differentiated offering with BaaS on its entire electric scooter range, with benefits like low upfront cost starting at ₹49,999, flexi-payment plans, starting at ₹862 per month; extended warranty

up to five years/70,000 km included in BaaS payment plans and unlimited monthly usage throughout the BaaS tenure of choice.

Gaurav Gupta, President – India 2W Business, TVS Motor Company said that the introduction of BaaS represents an important shift in customers' approach to EV ownership.

"By separating the vehicle price from the battery usage cost, we are enabling greater flexibility while providing customers a clear understanding of the overall cost of ownership."

ACCESSIBLE OPTION

The introduction of TVS Orbiter V1 reflects these insights, bringing a more accessible option for everyday urban commuting.

"Together with flexible ownership models like BaaS, we believe the TVS EV portfolio will continue to drive wider acceptance and accelerate EV adoption across India," said Aniruddha Haldar, Senior Vice President–Head Commuter & EV Business and Head Corporate Brand & Media, TVS Motor Company.

Stellantis seeks new deals to shore up European ops

Bloomberg

Stellantis NV is exploring deals with Chinese carmakers through which they would invest in the Fiat owner's struggling European operations, as the company focuses its own investments in the Americas, according to sources.

Company executives have met with China's Xiaomi Corp and Xpeng Inc to discuss options for an overhaul of Stellantis in Europe, including acquiring stakes in Maserati or other brands, said the sources.

CAPACITY BOOST

The talks have also covered access to automaking capacity as Chinese groups seek to grow in Europe, the people said.

"As part of its normal course of business, Stellantis holds discussions with a range of industry players around the world on various topics, always with the ultimate aim of providing cus-

tomers with the best mobility choices," the automaker said. "The company does not comment on speculations."

The discussions underline the divergent trajectories of Stellantis' businesses in Europe and the US, where the Jeep owner has kicked off investments of some \$13 billion to freshen its line-up, and where Chinese investments would be complicated by restrictions on the use of the country's technology in US cars.

The overhaul may eventually lead to a further separation between the US and European arms of a company formed through the 2021 combination of Fiat Chrysler Automobiles and PSA Group, sources said, though a full breakup is not the focus of current discussions.

"Stellantis states in the most categorical terms that there is no truth in the suggestion that it is considering a plan to split the company," the company said. "Any assertion to the contrary is pure invention."

QUICKLY.

US plans to suspend Jones Act to tame oil prices



The Trump administration plans to issue temporary waivers for a century-old maritime law requiring American-built ships to be used to transport goods between US ports as part of its effort to stop surging oil prices, according to people familiar with the matter. The 30-day waivers for the Jones Act would allow foreign tankers to help supply refiners on the East Coast with fuel from the Gulf Coast and elsewhere in the US, according to the people, who were not authorised to discuss the matter publicly. It comes as President Donald Trump considers multiple options to stem the dramatic rise in crude and gasoline amid the war in Iran. On Wednesday, the administration announced it would release 172 million barrels from the Strategic Petroleum Reserve as part of a coordinated effort with other nations to unleash 400 million barrels into the world market. BLOOMBERG

‘Govt reviewing fuel requests from Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Maldives’

TAKING STOCK. Decision to be taken based on the country’s own availability: MEA

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India is considering requests from countries such as Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Maldives for supplies of diesel and refined petroleum products amid the ongoing West Asia crisis and trade-route disruptions that has intensified concerns on energy security. New Delhi is reviewing the requests, while balancing its own domestic fuel requirements and refining capacity, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) has said. “India is a major exporter of refined petroleum products, especially to our neighbourhood. We have received a request from the government of Bangladesh for the supply of diesel, which is being examined...While diesel exports to Bangladesh have largely continued since 2017, India’s refining capacity, our own requirements and diesel availability will be factored in while taking decisions,” MEA Spokesperson Randhir



While diesel exports to Bangladesh have largely continued since 2017, India’s refining capacity, our own requirements and diesel availability will be factored in while taking decisions

RANDHIR JAISWAL
MEA Spokesperson

Jaiswal said on Thursday at a media briefing.

ENERGY REQUESTS Similar requests from other countries are also under consideration. “We have also received such requests from several other countries, including Sri Lanka and Maldives and these are being examined, taking into account

our own energy requirements and availability,” Jaiswal said. External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar is also in touch with his Iranian counterpart, Seyed Abbas Araghchi, and has been discussing matters related to the safety of shipping and India’s energy security, Jaiswal said. “External Affairs Minister

S Jaishankar and Foreign Minister of Iran have had three conversations in the recent days. The last one discussed issues pertaining to the safety of shipping and India’s energy security. Beyond that, it would be premature for me to say anything,” Jaiswal said at the briefing.

WAR IMPACT Following the US and Israeli strikes on Iran, shipping through the Strait of Hormuz has been severely disrupted, amid Iranian threats, attacks on vessels and reports of mines in the waterway.

This has effectively choked one of the world’s most vital energy corridors. This has posed a serious risk to energy supplies for India and neighbouring countries as their shipments sourced from Gulf producers such as Saudi Arabia, Iraq, the UAE, Kuwait and Qatar transit the Strait of Hormuz. On Wednesday, the Thai-flagged vessel *Mayuree Naree*, which was bound for India, was struck by a projectile in the Strait.

How smartphones became India’s largest export category in 2025

Yashaswani Chauhan
New Delhi

Smartphones have emerged as India’s largest export category by value in 2025, marking a decisive shift in the country’s trade composition. Smartphone exports rose from ₹0.31 lakh crore in 2021 to ₹2.63 lakh crore in 2025, overtaking standard high-speed diesel (₹1.42 lakh crore) and loose polished diamonds (₹1.09 lakh crore), according to the data from the Ministry of Commerce and Industry.

DATA FOCUS.

The rise of smartphones has been sharp and sustained. Exports expanded at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 53.45 per cent between 2021 and 2025. Within the electronics basket, smartphones remain the dominant driver, with exports increasing from ₹0.31 lakh crore in 2021 to ₹2.63 lakh crore in 2025.

The production in smartphones has also witnessed a jump from ₹2.22 lakh crore to ₹5.5 lakh crore between FY21 and FY25, at 19.9 per cent CAGR. With overall electronics exports at ₹3.3 lakh crore in FY25, mobile phones now account for a dominant share of the segment.

OTHER CATEGORIES Other electronics categories have grown at a slower pace. Computers and laptops reached ₹4,549 crore in 2025, while microchips and processor chips stood at ₹1,297 crore, highlighting the disproportionate weight of smartphones in the electronics export mix.

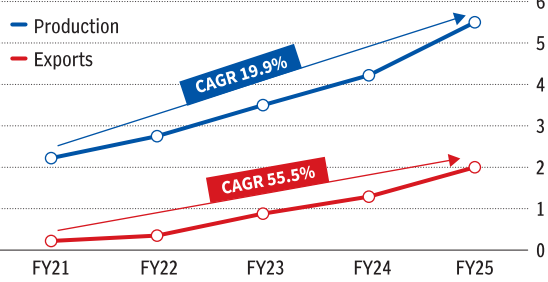
A key factor behind this surge has been the rapid scale-up of global smartphone manufacturing in India.

As reported by Bloomberg, Apple increased iPhone production in India by 53 per cent in 2025, assembling about 55 million units, up from 36 million a year earlier. India now accounts for roughly 25 per

Ringing in growth

Mobile exports grow nearly nine-fold since FY21, reaching ₹2 lakh crore in FY25

Mobile phone production and exports (in ₹ lakh crore)



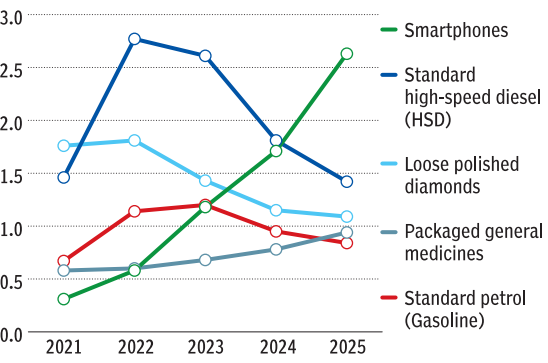
Smartphones, the largest component of electronic exports

Top 5 electronic goods export items by value (in ₹ crore)

	Smartphones	Computers & Laptops	High-Frequency Electronic Equipment	Microchips & Processor chips	Rechargeable Batteries
2021	30,848.7	165.6	33.0	1,216.7	89.8
2022	57,790.7	332.1	38.3	1,844.2	599.6
2023	1,17,914.6	1,154.4	35.9	1,006.3	1,141.0
2024	1,71,157.2	2,163.5	50.8	1,382.6	779.0
2025	2,62,452.0	4,549.0	67.0	1,297.3	520.0
CAGR	53.45%	94.00%	15.18%	1.29%	42.08%

Smartphones also the biggest export category by value

Top export items by value (in ₹ lakh crore)



Source: PIB, Ministry of Commerce and Industry

cent of Apple’s global iPhone output.

The shift reflects supply-chain diversification away from China amid US-China trade tensions and tariff-related headwinds.

Shipments from China faced pressures in 2025 due to US tariffs, prompting Apple to move a larger share of US-bound production to India. Suppliers, including Foxconn Technology Group, Tata Electronics and Pegatron Corp, assemble the latest iPhone models in India for

both export and domestic sales.

Production-linked incentives have helped offset structural cost disadvantages, including gaps in logistics and supply-chain depth, even though manufacturing costs remain higher than in China and Vietnam.

With smartphones now leading both the electronics basket and the overall export rankings, India’s trade growth is increasingly being anchored by high-value mobile manufacturing.

World faces largest-ever oil supply disruption, says IEA

Reuters
London

The war in West Asia is creating the biggest oil supply disruption in history, the International Energy Agency said on Thursday, a day after it agreed to release a record volume from strategic stockpiles to offset shortages and a spike in prices.

Global supply is expected to drop by 8 million barrels per day in March, the IEA said in its latest monthly oil market report — a volume equal to almost 8 per cent of world demand — due to the blocking of the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow channel along the Iranian coast, since the US and Israel began air-

strikes on Iran on February 28.

The outlook from the IEA, which advises industrialised countries, contrasts with its earlier warnings of a sizeable surplus on the market for the first quarter of 2026.

It added, however, that supply could rise in April as some Middle East Gulf producers use alternative export routes to bypass the Strait of Hormuz, and said that, for the year, production would still expand more quickly than global demand.

PRODUCTION SLASHED Oil prices rose on Thursday, as Iran stepped up attacks on oil and transport facilities across the Middle East, raising fears of a prolonged con-



flict and continued oil-flow disruptions through the Strait.

Brent crude, which hit \$119.50 a barrel on Monday, its highest since mid-2022, was up 5 per cent on Thursday at just below \$97 a barrel.

Middle East Gulf countries including Iraq, Qatar,

Kuwait, the UAE and Saudi Arabia have cut total oil production by at least 10 million barrels per day as a result of the conflict, the IEA said, adding that without a rapid restart of shipping flows these losses were set to increase.

“Shut-in upstream production will take weeks and, in some cases, months to return to pre-crisis levels depending on the degree of field complexity and the timing for workers, equipment and resources to return to the region,” the agency said.

The IEA on Wednesday agreed to release a record 400 million barrels of oil from strategic stockpiles held by member nations to combat a spike in prices

since the start of the war on Iran. IEA Executive Director Fatih Birol, speaking in Istanbul, said the agency’s decision had already had a “strong impact” on energy markets, which were in an “extremely critical period.” He declined to respond to a question on the daily pace of release from stockpiles.

The Middle East crisis was also curbing oil demand as airlines cancel flights, the IEA said, while a more precarious economic outlook and higher prices were posing a risk to the demand forecast.

World demand was expected to be around 1 million bpd lower than earlier estimates during March and April, the IEA said.

Automakers line up 25+ EV launches to charge up market as subsidies taper off

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

India’s electric vehicle (EV) market may be entering a brief pause before its next growth phase, but automakers are preparing for a major push as the industry transitions from subsidy-driven adoption to a more competitive, product-led market. More than 25 new EV models are expected to be launched in FY27, ranging from electric motorcycles such as Royal Enfield’s Flying Flea C6 to SUVs like the Tata Sierra EV.

Industry estimates suggest the pipeline could include about 10 electric two-wheelers and 7–8 passenger EVs, along with an expanding line-up of electric cargo vehicles and three-wheelers. Automakers are betting that improvements in range, performance and technology will help sustain demand even as government incentives taper off.

Subsidies under the PM E-

Drive scheme are set to expire on March 31. Analysts expect a surge in purchases in the weeks leading up to the deadline, as buyers rush to secure incentives, potentially marking the final phase of policy-led EV adoption.

EV penetration across key segments began stabilising in FY26. Electric two-wheelers accounted for about 6.6 per cent of total sales, while electric passenger vehicles remained at around 3.5 per cent, according to a BNP Paribas report.

Registrations for electric two-wheelers, passenger vehicles and three-wheelers declined month-on-month in February, largely due to fewer days in the month and a high base in January. However, penetration levels remained broadly stable.

E-MOTORCYCLES

Among the most closely watched launches in FY27 is Royal Enfield’s Flying Flea C6, expected in April. The motorcycle marks the brand’s first electric offering

- Royal Enfield’s Flying Flea C6 is likely to arrive in April
- TVS Motor is preparing to launch the Jupiter Electric
- Hero MotoCorp is exploring the category with its Vida VXZ performance concept
- One of the most anticipated PV launches is the Tata Sierra EV
- Mahindra Electric, Bajaj Auto, Piaggio and Euler Motors are set to expand their passenger electric 3-wheeler portfolios



and draws inspiration from the wartime Flying Flea model, combining retro styling with performance aimed at mid-capacity petrol motorcycles. A scrambler-style variant, the Flying Flea S6 is expected to follow later.

Several manufacturers are preparing to enter the electric motorcycle segment. The eFX 30, expected toward the year end, will be TVS Motor’s first dedicated electric motorcycle platform targeting performance-oriented riders in the Apache segment.

Hero MotoCorp is exploring the category with its Vida VXZ performance concept, developed in collaboration

with US-based electric motorcycle maker Zero Motorcycles. The company is also reportedly developing an electric version of its popular Splendor commuter motorcycle under the internal codename “Project AEDA”. Start-ups are also betting on performance-focused electric motorcycles. Bengaluru-based Ultraviolet Automotive is working on new models following the launch of its F77 platform, while Ola Electric has showcased its futuristic Diamond-head electric motorcycle concept.

These developments suggest electrification is beginning to extend beyond scooter-

ers into the motorcycle segment, which dominates India’s two-wheeler market.

E-SCOOTER LAUNCHES

Meanwhile, scooters remain the primary battleground for EV adoption. Honda has already introduced the Activa e: and CUV e: electric scooters and is expected to expand the line-up while building a battery-swapping ecosystem. TVS Motor is preparing to launch Jupiter Electric around August, while Greaves Electric Mobility is developing a sixth-generation Ampere scooter aimed at the sub-₹1 lakh commuter segment.

Japan’s Suzuki is expected

to introduce Burgman Electric, while Yamaha’s upcoming AEROX-E targets younger urban buyers through its premium ‘Blue Square’ retail network.

Competition in the segment is intensifying. According to BNP Paribas data, TVS Motor currently leads the electric two-wheeler market with around 28.5 per cent share, followed by Bajaj Auto, while Ola Electric’s market share has declined in recent months.

ELECTRIC SUV

In the passenger vehicle segment, one of the most anticipated launches is the Tata Sierra EV, built on Tata Motors’ Acti.ev platform, with an expected range of 500 km. Mahindra & Mahindra is reading the XEV 7e, a three-row electric SUV based on its INGLO architecture, along with the BE 07 in the mid-size family SUV segment.

Global manufacturers are also expanding their EV portfolios in India. Kia is expected to introduce the

Syros EV, while Mercedes-Benz plans new-generation CLA Electric. Other luxury manufacturers, including Audi and BMW, are preparing competing models, while Hyundai is expected to introduce its Genesis luxury EV models such as the GV60.

Electrification is also advancing in commercial mobility. Electric variants already account for more than half of India’s three-wheeler sales, making them the most mature EV segment in the country. Companies such as Mahindra Electric, Bajaj Auto, Piaggio and Euler Motors are expected to expand their electric cargo and passenger three-wheeler portfolios, alongside new electric cargo four-wheelers for last-mile delivery and e-commerce logistics.

If the upcoming launches gain traction, FY27 could mark the beginning of the second phase of India’s EV transition — driven less by subsidies and more by vehicle choices across segments, industry insiders say.

Infosys expands development centre in Mohali

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Infosys has announced the expansion of its Mohali development centre with a formal groundbreaking ceremony held at the campus, strengthening its presence in North India.

As part of this expansion, Infosys will develop a new Software Development Block along with supporting facilities. The expansion is planned to have a built-up area of about 3.5 lakh sq ft and will seat about 3,000 employees, strengthening Infosys’ ability to design, co-create and deploy AI-led solutions at enterprise scale.

The current operations at Infosys Mohali, with close to 1,000 employees, delivers advanced digital services to global clients across key sectors, including banking, financial services and insurance (BFSI), retail and healthcare. The expanded campus will further enhance Infosys’ capabilities in cloud, AI, application development and digital transformation, enabling the company to better meet the growing demands of its global clients and help them unlock tangible AI-driven value at scale.

EMERGING HUB

S Bhagwant Singh Mann, Chief Minister of Punjab, said, “The expansion of Infosys’ Mohali DC strengthens Punjab’s position as an emerging hub for technology and innovation. This investment will create significant employment opportunities for the youth of Punjab and neighbouring States while bolstering the state’s IT ecosystem. We look forward to Infosys’ continued efforts in driving technology-led and inclusive economic growth in the region.”

Razorpay bets on AI agents, global expansion to power next phase of growth

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

Fintech major Razorpay is doubling down on artificial intelligence-led products, international expansion and new software offerings as it looks to unlock the next phase of growth beyond its core payments business. Co-founder and Managing Director Shashank Kumar said.

The company is building AI-powered agents that can automate operational workflows across payments, finance and payroll, allowing businesses — especially small and mid-size firms — to handle routine tasks

without human intervention. The push comes as Razorpay looks to deepen its value proposition for its large base of start-ups and SMB customers.

“We are rebuilding the company with AI at its base,” Kumar said in an interview. “There are a lot of operational tasks in payments, finance and payroll that can be managed by AI.”

AI AGENTS

Razorpay recently launched products such as Agent Studio and Liquid, which allow businesses to deploy AI agents to perform tasks such as resolving payment failures, tracking invoices or fol-

lowing up on collections. The company expects these tools to automate several day-to-day operational processes for businesses.

While pricing for these AI products currently depends on the complexity of tasks, Kumar said the economics of deploying AI are likely to improve significantly over the next year as models become cheaper and companies optimise usage.

“Today we might be using more expensive models, but 12 months from now we’ll have better optimisation and may use cheaper or open-source models for some tasks,” he said, adding that the current focus is less on



Shashank Kumar, Co-Founder, Razorpay

token costs and more on driving behavioural change among users.

The AI push is also expected to help Razorpay scale operations without proportionately increasing costs.

According to Kumar, AI can reduce the cost of serving customers even as the company expands its user base.

“If we go from serving one lakh customers to two lakh customers and costs rise in sync, that’s not the direction we want. The leverage AI provides allows us to take those savings and reinvest them into building more products,” he said.

SMB FOCUS

Razorpay sees the biggest opportunity for AI adoption among start-ups, small businesses and mid-market companies, which typically lack the resources to build internal automation tools.

“Enterprises have very varied requirements and often build their own systems,” Kumar said. “But SMBs are always looking for ways to become more efficient and reduce burn. AI tools can help smaller teams get much more out of technology.”

INTERNATIONAL PLAY

Beyond India, Razorpay is strengthening its presence in South-East Asia as part of its global growth strategy.

The company has already established operations in Malaysia and entered Singapore last year. Kumar said the focus in FY26 will be on scaling these markets further. “We’re doing really well

in Malaysia. In Singapore, we’ve reached some early milestones and this year the focus will be to grow those markets further,” he said.

Razorpay is also open to acquisitions in both domestic and overseas markets as it looks to expand its capabilities and market presence.

On the much-anticipated public listing, Kumar said discussions around a potential IPO are being handled by the company’s board, though going public remains a long-term goal. The fintech firm currently has a strong balance sheet and does not face immediate pressure to raise fresh capital, he said.

QUICKLY.

ED attaches ₹581 crore of Reliance Group firms



New Delhi: Enforcement Directorate on Thursday said it has attached fresh assets worth more than ₹581 crore of RHFL and RCFL, companies of Reliance Group Chairman Anil Ambani. An order was issued on March 11 to attach land parcels in Goa, Kerala, Karnataka, Punjab, Tamil Nadu, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Jharkhand, Maharashtra, Delhi, West Bengal, Andhra Pradesh and Rajasthan, ED stated. The properties belong to Reliance Home Finance Ltd and Reliance Commercial Finance Ltd, the agency said. The Enforcement Directorate had attached assets of Anil Ambani's Reliance Group earlier as well. ■

CARS24 acquires utility platform Vehicle Info



New Delhi: Global used-car marketplace CARS24 acquired automotive utility platform Vehicle Info from Surat-based Vasundhara Infotech LLP for an undisclosed amount. Vehicle Info enables users to access a range of vehicle-related services through a single digital platform. The application allows vehicle owners to check registration details, view and pay traffic challans, verify insurance validity, track service history and access other essential vehicle information online. A statement said the Gurgaon-based firm looks to build a full-stack digital platform. ■

Doctors welcome govt advisory on weightloss drug promotions

AWARENESS PUSH. They red-flagged the high visibility generated through ads, hoardings and online campaigns

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai

As global drugmakers Novo Nordisk and Eli Lilly slug it out in the marketplace over their recently introduced weightloss and diabetes-linked obesity products, the Centre's strongly worded advisory on "so-called awareness campaigns" linked to prescription drugs could not have come at a better time, say doctors and pharma observers.

Novo's weightloss and diabetes products Wegovy and Ozempic (injectable semaglutide), respectively, are available in India through existing networks, and local partnerships with Emcure, and Abbott. Eli Lilly sells Mounjaro and has partnered with Cipla. The marketplace is only set to get crowded as over 50 branded generic products wait in the wings for launch on day 1 of semaglutide losing patent protec-



THE PRICING. Industry-watchers expect generics to be priced at one-third to one-fifth the cost of the original product

tion next week. Industry-watchers expect the generics to be priced at one-third to one-fifth (₹3,000-₹4000) the cost of the original. Domestic firms in the fray include Sun Pharma, Dr Reddy's Labs, Glenmark, Lupin, Mankind Pharma, Alkem, Alembic, Torrent Pharma and Zydus Lifesciences.

Taking note of the direct or indirect (surrogate) pro-

motional activities, including disease awareness campaigns, digital media outreach, and other communications from pharmaceutical companies, relating to GLP-1 receptor agonists and similar prescription drugs indicated for obesity and metabolic disorders, the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) stated that prescription drugs are to be pre-

scribed by registered medical practitioners or specialists, as originally approved by the regulatory authority.

Doctors, too, had red-flagged the high-profile visibility through advertisements, hoardings at hospitals and online campaigns.

WHY IT IS TIMELY

Diabetologist Dr V Mohan said the advisory is "timely". At present, there are two major companies selling the product. But when 30-odd more come out with similar products, "there will be cut throat competition", said Mohan, Chairman, Dr Mohan's Diabetes Specialities Centre.

The approval of these products indicated that an MD or endocrinologist could prescribe these products, he said, cautioning that reports indicated the product was available through non-authorised methods. Who would be accountable if

there are adverse events like vision-loss, he asked.

The CDSCO advisory said any ad promoting prescription-only medicines to the general public or exaggerating therapeutic efficacy, suggests assured or guaranteed weightloss outcomes or induces demand for pharmacological therapy may amount to misleading promotion and may attract action under relevant provisions of the Drugs Rules, 1945.

The advisory is proactive, said Sheetal Sapale, Vice-President, Commercial at Pharmarack Technologies, as companies could leverage the visibility of the obesity-oriented advertisements and offer products at lower prices. "People need to understand, they will regain weight on stopping the medicine, and that there could be gastro issues," she said, adding that reports of vision loss, however rare, is a large number in a populous country like India.

Amazon Business growing at 40% CAGR

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Amazon Business, the B2B marketplace of the e-commerce major, witnessed 35 per cent year-on-year growth in 2025 led by stronger adoption in tier-2 and tier-3 markets. It also grew its B2B consumer base at a CAGR of over 30 per cent over the past five years.

Mitranjan Bhaduri, Director, Amazon Business, told *businessline*, "Over the past five years, overall sales have grown at a CAGR of over 40 per cent, bulk sales at nearly 35 per cent, and the re-

gistered customer base at 30 per cent. The strongest adoption has come from businesses in tier 2 and tier 3 cities. They now represent over 70 per cent of the customer base." The company also said that Amazon Business has enabled businesses across India to realise over ₹2,000 crore in financial value in 2025. "This reflects the tangible value unlocked when organisations move from fragmented, offline buying to a structured, transparent and data-driven approach. The financial value includes savings from cashback rewards, bulk discounts and exclusive deals on Amazon



This reflects the tangible value unlocked when organisations move from fragmented, offline buying to a structured, transparent and data-driven approach

MITRANJAN BHADURI
Director, Amazon Business

Business. A significant portion of this value was also driven by seamless GST-



compliant invoicing on Amazon Business, which has brought long-overdue trans-

parency to business procurement," he added.

STRONG UPTICK

Bhaduri explained that certain categories such as IT and office supplies, which are ubiquitous needs across businesses, have seen strong uptick. "So, for example, PC and IT products, office supplies and stationary or housekeeping supplies are categories that we've consistently seen being ordered across industry verticals. And one of the large industry verticals for us is manufacturing where we have seen encouraging growth," Bhaduri added.

Vi to meet institutional investors mid-March

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Vodafone Idea (Vi) will be meeting institutional investors in Singapore and Hong Kong in the first half of next week as per a stock exchange filing by the company.

The announcement is in line with the telecom service provider's January plans to ramp up funding and direct the investments towards improving customer experience.

MEETING DATES

"Pursuant to Regulation 30 of the SEBI Listing Regulations, we wish to inform you that the representatives of the Company will be meeting institutional investors," Vi stated, listing March 16



RENEWED ENERGY. Vi plans to invest ₹45,000 crore over three years, with double-digit revenue growth ambitions and a threefold increase in cash EBITDA and subscriber additions

and 17 as the dates of meeting. It added that no unpublished price sensitive information is proposed to be shared during the meetings. In its last investor meet-

ing, the telco showed a renewed energy and plan to gain funding.

Abhijit Kishore, CEO, Vi, said the company was hard-pressed for investment for

the longest time owing to AGR dues that impacted funding opportunities which in turn worsened the AGR troubles.

VICIOUS CYCLE

Kishore said the vicious cycle impacted network experience and brand perception leading to a loss of customer confidence and subscriber base.

"There was an unprecedented force which got unleashed on us over these years," Kishore further added. However, the company expressed renewed enthusiasm since the Union Cabinet announced the relief package, including the freezing of AGR dues at ₹87,695 crore and a staggered payment schedule up to financial year 2041.

Vi now plans to invest

₹45,000 crore in its business over the next three years, with double-digit revenue growth ambitions and a threefold increase in cash EBITDA and sustained subscriber additions.

CAPITAL INFUSION

It also talked about taking planned capital infusion to over ₹60,000 crore and exploring ₹25,000 crore in bank funding and ₹10,000 crore through a non-funded facility, with no plans for equity infusion.

Shortly after the AGR dues were announced, senior public sector bank officials had told *businessline* that the government's moratorium provides comfort to lenders for incremental lending and that public sector banks could look to participate in the same in the funding.

J&J launches next-gen intraocular lens

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Johnson & Johnson will expand its portfolio of presbyopia-correcting intraocular lenses (PC-IOL) with the roll-out of TECNIS Odyssey IOL in India. The new full visual range IOL offers high-quality and continuous vision with unmatched range.

This will allow patients to see clearly across all ranges minimising their need for glasses. TECNIS Odyssey IOL offers consistently clear, high-contrast vision, said the company. Burzin Shahana, Country Manager, Surgical Vision India & South Asia, Johnson & Johnson, said the TECNIS Odyssey IOL addresses a significant unmet need for cataract patients seeking greater spectacle-independence. Its introduction in India expands access to advanced IOL technology designed to deliver high-quality, continuous vision across distances, he added.

Currently, an estimated 94 million people aged 50 years and over have moderate-to-severe distance vision impairment or blindness that could be corrected through lens replacement surgery. These figures are projected to increase, since presbyopia and cataract development are part of the ageing process, said the company.

thehindubusinessline. Classifieds

PERSONAL CHANGE OF NAME

I, VIDYA ANI NAIR D/o. Chandran Chittathukatti W/o. Anil Raveendran Nair, Residing at Sunny Seasons, Block 13, Flat 4A, Kamalgazi, South 24 Parganas, Kolkata, Pin-700103, West Bengal, India have changed my name and shall henceforth be known as VIDYA ANIL NAIR as declared before the Notary Public, Kolkata, vide affidavit Dated 10th March, 2026. VIDYA ANI NAIR and VIDYA ANIL NAIR both are same and identical person.

To advertise visit
www.thehinduads.com
Toll Free: 1800 102 4161

Zen Tech soars on IP-led defence simulation dominance

KV Kurmanath
Hyderabad

How this Hyderabad entrepreneur created a unique global arms simulation company is a masterclass in IP-led growth for Indian SMEs. The facility at the Hard-ware Park mirrors a high-stakes battlefield, where the thunderous rattle of AK-47s and heavy armour, including military tanks, creates a space reverberating with the intensity of combat.

PRODUCT-FOCUSED

By ditching the 'service-provider' mindset that was prevalent three decades ago, Ashok Atluri transformed the fledgling IT services company into a product-focused one by foraying into the small-arms training simulator business soon after its 1993 inception.

"As computer assembly became a low-margin commodity, we recognised the immense potential in simulators. At the time, there were very few firing ranges in

India, and urban expansion was consuming existing ones. We saw a massive demand for range-replacement technology," Ashok Atluri, Founder of Zen Technologies, said.

IP STRATEGY

Giving the analogy of the dentist (service-based) versus the author (product-based), the business chose to be 'authors', focusing on high-value Intellectual Property (IP) and continuous R&D to ensure sustained innovation rather than relying on service-based work.

"Actually, this became a challenge for us in bidding for government tenders for nearly two decades, as the rules insisted on the three-vendor norm to avoid monopolies," Atluri added.

According to Atluri, this in turn resulted in the cancellation of tenders because we were the sole vendor.

This, however, was changed after Manohar Parrikar took over as the Defence Minister in 2014, making it easier to participate in



Anti-drone system developed by Zen Technologies

the tenders, Atluri further noted.

POLICY BOOST

Citing Apple's model, he said that developing IP would help companies earn more, while simply producing goods would yield smaller returns.

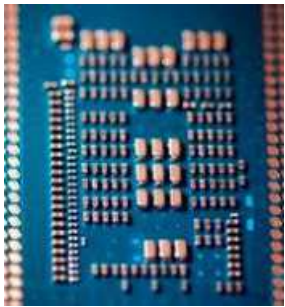
"As a technocrat and businessman, he (Parrikar) understood world-class defence products rarely have multiple vendors. He introduced the Indigenously Designed, Developed and Man-

It also developed competencies such as GPS spoofing (sending stronger signals to mislead a drone about its location) and hard kill systems (AI-powered weaponry)

ufactured (IDDM) category. This was a crucial distinction that boosted indigenous defence production," Atluri said. With eight subsidiaries now under its umbrella, Zen Technologies has competencies in electronic warfare, army and naval simulators, anti-drone technology and components, automated weapons and surveillance systems. "Post December 31, 2025, we received orders aggregating to ₹345 crore, taking cumulative order inflows over the last four months to ₹931 crore. The majority of

India plans \$11 b fund to support local chipmaking

Bloomberg



India plans to unveil a more than ₹1 lakh crore (\$10.8 billion) fund aimed at bolstering domestic chipmaking, advancing its ambitious bid to become a global manufacturing hub.

The fund, which will provide subsidies for chip design projects, manufacturing equipment and supply chain development, may be launched in two to three months, people familiar with the matter said, asking not to be named as the plan isn't yet public.

The plan is still under discussion and may change.

EARLY STAGES

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is trying to accelerate India's chip campaign, which is in early stages with just a handful of major projects underway.

Governments around the world are ramping up support for their chip industries to become more self-sustaining and fulfill rising demand from developers of everything from AI and smartphones to cars and appliances.

India's push, though smaller in scale, is similar to the \$52 billion US Chips and Science Act that funds local chipmaking capacity.

In China, authorities provide funding for chip firms in part through giant investment vehicles that invest in key companies across the ecosystem.

India is hoping to woo major chipmakers to the world's most populous country with its engineering and design talent as well as subsidies in much the same way it helped Apple Inc expand in the region.

The US giant now assembles 25 per cent of iPhones in the South Asian nation.

India's tech ministry, in charge of the fund, didn't respond to a request for comment.

The new semiconductor incentives will tie in with other smartphone and component subsidies that the government offers to boost domestic manufacturing and exports, the people said.

Indian officials and smartphone players are discussing a fresh round of subsidies, with the current programme expiring March 31.

The chip initiative would build on India's \$10 billion incentive programme from 2021, which offered to bear half the cost of setting up semiconductor projects. That effort helped kickstart India's chip journey, drawing companies like US memory maker Micron Technology Inc, which is establishing an assembly facility in Gujarat.

Indian salt-to-software conglomerate Tata Group is also building a semiconductor fabrication plant in Modi's home State of Gujarat, along with a separate chip packaging unit.

VALUE CHAIN

Several other ventures tied to chip manufacturing and packaging, including Foxconn Technology Group's test and assembly facility, have also been announced as part of the government's incentive programme.

While India's early projects are focusing on less-sophisticated chips, it has ambitions to move up the value chain to more advanced semiconductors.

New Delhi has set its sights on catching up with leading producers such as Taiwan, South Korea and the US.

APPOINTMENT

DREDGING CORPORATION OF INDIA LIMITED
(Under consortium of Visakhapatnam Port Authority, Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority, Paradip Port Authority and Deendayal Port Authority)
H.O.: H B Colony, Seethammadhara, VISAKHAPATNAM – 530 022
ADVT. No.01/2026

DCIL invites applications for the post of

Post	Vacancy
Executive Director (Finance)	01

For detailed advertisement and submission of online applications, please visit our website <https://www.dredge-india.com/career>

Commencement of online Application	18.03.2026 from 10.00 Hrs
Last date for submission of online Application	08.04.2026 till 18.00 Hrs

भारतीय बागान प्रबन्ध संस्थान बेंगलुरु
INDIAN INSTITUTE OF PLANTATION MANAGEMENT BENGALURU
(An Autonomous Organization of the Ministry of Commerce & Industry, GOI)

Recruitment Notification

Applications are invited from eligible candidates for the post of **Consultant (Agricultural Exports)-2 Nos and Data Analyst-1 Nos** on contractual basis.

The details of Job description can be obtained from website www.iipmb.edu.in. Eligible candidates may email their CV to: careers@iipmb.edu.in on or before **31st March 2026**.

Date: 13/03/2026
Notification No.: 04/2026

Sd/- DIRECTOR

Government of Kerala

Published Tenders from 09-03-2026 to 11-03-2026

Directorate of Medical Education

Tender ID: 2026 DME 846451_1 * Superintendent * supply of NICU instruments/consumables (neonatal care servc * Closing Date: 21-Mar-2026 * PAC: Rs500000

Visit <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> for more details.
Ro.No:09-11/Mar/2026/PRD/(N)13

COCHIN INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LIMITED
CIAL/CIVIL/711 **TENDER NOTICE** 13/03/2026

Item rate tenders are invited from experienced civil contractors for the below-mentioned work at Cochin International Airport.

Name of Work	Estimated Amount (Rs.)	EMD (Rs.)	Period of Contract
Re-routing of storm water drain in the northern side of Terminal 3	59.73 Lakhs	1 Lakh	04 Months

For more details visit our website www.cial.aero. **Sd/- MANAGING DIRECTOR**

COCHIN INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LIMITED
CIAL/COMM/BDDS/2026/02 **TENDER NOTICE** 13.03.2026

Online Item rate E-tenders are invited from reputed agencies for the work mentioned below at Cochin International Airport.

Sl No.	Name of Work	Estimate	EMD	Period
1	SITC of Bomb Suit	Rs.75 Lakhs + GST	Rs.1.50 Lakhs	3 Months

Interested firms may register themselves on the online E-Tendering portal <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> and then download the Tender documents. For eligibility criteria and other details visit our website www.cial.aero. All further updates and details regarding this tender will be available on the E-Tendering portal: <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> **Sd/- Managing Director**

QUICKLY.

Aluminium nears 4-year high on supply fears



London: Aluminium prices hit their highest level in almost four years on Thursday on worries of tighter supply to Europe and other regions as the Middle East conflict disrupts shipments via the Strait of Hormuz. Benchmark three-month aluminium on the LME rose 0.6 per cent to \$3,478.50 a tonne by 1111 GMT. Copper fell 0.1 per cent to \$13,032. REUTERS

Cocoa prices reverse gains, coffee rises

Cocoa prices fell sharply as investors took the view that the past eight days of successive gains were overdone. London cocoa fell 4.2 per cent to 2,380 pounds a tonne at 1326 GMT. New York cocoa lost 4.1 per cent to \$3,290. Arabica coffee rose 2.9 per cent to \$2.9585 per lb despite a bumper crop prediction in Brazil. Robusta coffee rose 1.7 per cent to \$3,614 a tonne. REUTERS

Crude oil jumps 7% as Iran escalates attacks



London: Crude oil prices rose sharply as Iran stepped up attacks on oil and transport facilities across the Middle East. Brent futures climbed \$6.41 to \$98.45 a barrel by 1235 GMT, while US West Texas Intermediate crude was up \$5.98 at \$93.23. REUTERS

Govt may extend duty-free import of pulses on Iran war, El Nino possibility

PRICE SHIELD. Stakeholders feel the govt will extend purchases of tur and urad to keep inflation under check

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

Amid forecast of El Nino this year and ongoing disruptions in war-torn West Asia pushing up freight costs, the government is likely to extend the duty-free import window for pulses, such as pigeon pea (tur) and black matpe (urad), to ensure adequate supplies.

The duty-free import window for pigeon pea (tur) and black matpe (urad) ends on March 31, but the stakeholders are expecting an extension given that India is facing a deficit in these categories of pulses.

Another factor that could prompt the government to extend the duty free import policy is the decline in domestic production during the current crop year to June.

Per the second advance estimates, tur production during 2025-26 is down 4.66 per



STATUS QUO. The trade expects the government to continue with the policy as it stabilised the domestic prices

cent at 34.55 lakh tonnes (lt) over 36.24 lt a year ago.

Similarly, urad production was down 10.7 per cent during kharif at 12.06 lt (13.41 lt) and 8.14 per cent down in the rabi season at 5.08 lt (5.53 lt).

“The government is already concerned about inflation amid the war as rising oil prices are expected to

push up freight and insurance costs. While supplies may not be disrupted, shipping companies are likely to levy higher war-risk premiums, increasing overall import costs. The fall in rupee is also adding to the increase in costs. Even packaging expenses have surged, with poly propylene bag prices doubling from ₹11 to ₹23

FSSAI mandates registration for milk producers, vendors

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has asked all milk producers and milk vendors to mandatorily obtain registration or licences.

It has also directed the States to ensure that milk producers operate with the requisite registration or licences.

In an advisory, FSSAI said it had come to its notice that some milk producers and vendors were operating without registering them-

selves or obtaining licences to carry out food business activities.

“All milk producers (other than those who are registered members of a dairy co-operative society under the Cooperative Societies Act and supply or sell the entire milk to the society) and milk vendors are hereby advised to mandatorily register themselves with the FSSAI before commencing or continuing their operations,” the advisory said.

STRICT COMPLIANCE
The Authority said that in



view of recent incidents involving suspected milk adulteration, strict compliance with registration and licensing requirements must be ensured.

“Central enforcement authorities and all States/UTs

within a week, raising costs by about ₹250 per tonne. Given these uncertainties and the fact that India remains deficit in pulses, the government should avoid restricting imports and ensure that inflows continue,” said Bimal Kothari, Chairman, India Pulses and Grains Association.

STABLE LOCAL PRICES
While imports of tur and urad are duty free, pulses such as chana and masur (lentil) attract a duty of 10 per cent and yellow peas 30 per cent.

The trade expects the government to continue with the same policy as it stabilised the prices domestically, Kothari said. He said that the government should use this opportunity to build strong buffer stocks as the domestic crops of chana and lentils were good.

Satish Upadhyay, Secretary, IPGA, said the extension of the pulses import policy

will hopefully come by next week.

Considering that there's a high chance of occurrence of El Nino and impacting monsoon, which has been predicted by the World Meteorological Department, the government should allow duty free imports to keep inflation under check, he said.

‘AWAITING EXTENSION’
The government is likely to extend the duty-free imports of tur and urad as the domestic production is less than last year, said Rahul Chauhan of IGrain India. The duty structure on all other pulses may remain the same as prices are under control, he said.

“The government should extend the OGL imports of pigeon pea and black matpe beyond March as the domestic crop availability is not so great,” said B Krishnamurthy, MD of Four P International, an importer in Chennai.

The food safety authority has also directed States to ensure that milk producers operate with the requisite licences

are requested to direct the concerned designated officers, Central licensing authorities and food safety officers to verify that all such milk producers and vendors possess a valid registration certificate or licence, as applicable,” it added.

The FSSAI also directed that periodic inspections of milk chillers be conducted to ensure proper storage temperature and adherence to necessary standards, so as to prevent spoilage and safeguard public health.

“States/UTs are also directed to undertake special registration drives in their respective jurisdictions to ensure that all milk producers (who are not members of dairy co-operative societies) and milk vendors obtain the requisite FSSAI registration certificate or licence, as applicable,” the Authority added.

Cotton procurement at MSP rises 4% to cross over 104 lakh bales

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

Procurement of cotton at the minimum support price (MSP) by the state-run Cotton Corporation of India (CCI) for the ongoing 2025-26 marketing season has crossed 104 lakh bales (of 170 kg each), about 4 per cent higher than last year's 100.16 lakh bales.

The cotton procurement season is nearing completion, with March 13 being the last date for MSP purchase.

Lalit Kumar Gupta, Chairman and MD, CCI, told *businessline* that procurement had reached 104.01 lakh bales so far. The CCI has also started liquidating part of the stocks.

TELANGANA LEADS

Gupta said the agency had sold about 17.5 lakh bales from the 2025-26 crop so far.

Among the States, Telangana tops the list where the maximum quantity of cotton has been procured, followed by Maharashtra and Gujarat.

The CCI has purchased 31.70 lakh bales in Telangana and 27.23 lakh bales in Maharashtra. In Gujarat, procurement so far stands at 19.96 lakh bales.

Karnataka is the fourth-largest State in procurement with 7.01 lakh bales. In Madhya Pradesh, procurement has crossed 5.55 lakh bales, while Andhra Pradesh has recorded 3.9 lakh bales. In Rajasthan, the quantity procured stands at 3.46 lakh bales.

The CCI has purchased 2.7 lakh bales in Odisha, 2.04 lakh bales in Haryana, and 0.47 lakh bales in Punjab.

Cotton procurement during 2025-26 is likely to be the second-highest since 2019-20, when the state agency procured over 105 lakh bales.

Last year, the CCI procurement stood at about 100 lakh bales.

ESTIMATES DIVERGE

According to the Second Advance Estimates released earlier this week by the Agriculture Ministry, cotton production in 2025-26 is pegged at 290.91 lakh bales, lower than last year's 297.24 lakh bales, mainly due to reduced acreage and crop damage from excess rain.

However, the Cotton Association of India (CAI) recently revised its crop estimate upward by around 2.5 per cent to 317 lakh bales, citing higher-than-expected output in Maharashtra and Telangana.

The CAI projected a year-end surplus of 122.59 lakh bales for the 2025-26 season, 56 per cent higher year-on-year, driven by record imports of about 50 lakh bales during the year.

Buy natural gas if it breaks out of ₹310 with stop-loss at ₹295

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

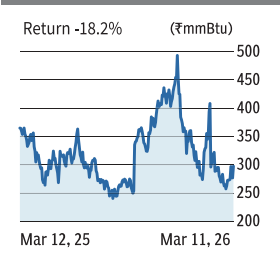
Natural gas futures, currently trading at ₹304 per mmBtu, have seen higher volatility over the past week. Nevertheless, the price action during this period shows a positive tilt.

COMMODITY CALL.

The March futures surpassed the barrier at ₹290 and today, it opened above another resistance at ₹296 following a gap-up beginning. Also, the price is now above both 21- and 50-day moving averages.

While the above factors point to a positive chart set up, natural gas futures has a hurdle at ₹310.

Only a decisive breakout of this can turn the outlook positive.



Until then, the bears will have a chance to drag the contract lower. A breakout of ₹310 could potentially lift natural gas futures to ₹340 or to ₹350.

On the other hand, if the contract declines from the current level, it could drop to ₹275. Subsequent support is at ₹258.

TRADE STRATEGY

Stay out for now. Buy natural gas futures (March) if it breaks out of ₹310. Place stop-loss at ₹295 at first.

When the price rises to ₹330, tighten the stop-loss to ₹310. Exit at ₹340.

Global tensions weigh on edible oil supplies: SEA

Our Bureau
Mangaluru



Recent conflicts, particularly in West Asia and ongoing tensions affecting the Black Sea have created significant volatility and supply concerns for India's edible oil market, according to BV Mehta, Executive Director of the Solvent Extractors' Association of India (SEA).

He said the risks of disrupted sunflower oil shipments from Russia and East Europe and higher freight costs for palm oil had caused price hikes in commodities such as sunflower oil, forcing traders and consumers to monitor the situation to navigate the supply chain risks.

Prices of edible oils such as sunflower oil have shown volatility, experiencing price increases in the domestic market due to concerns over supply chain disruptions.

To mitigate the impact of the Russia-Ukraine war, India has been exploring long-term contracts with Mercosur countries (Argentina, Brazil, Paraguay and Uruguay) for soybean and sunflower oil, he said.

According to SEA data, India imported 9.11 lakh tonnes (lt) of sunflower oil during the first four months of the oil year 2025-26 (November-October) against 11.47 lt in the corresponding period of the previous oil year.

PALM OIL FOR BIOFUEL

On palm oil prices, Mehta said biofuel producers were showing more interest in palm oil-based biodiesel as a result of the rise in crude oil prices driven by the war in West Asia.

This could strengthen near-term demand and prices for palm oil, especially in South-East Asia, he said.

India imported 27.57 lt of palm oil (including crude palm oil and RBD palmolein) during November-February

of the oil year 2025-26 against 19.96 lt in the corresponding period of the oil year 2024-25.

India imported 15.43 lt of soybean oil during November-February 2025-26 (17.40 lt).

RUPEE DEPRECIATION

He said the prices of palm oil and soybean oil remained at more or less the same level in February 2026 when compared to February 2025, and sunflower oil jumped by over \$200 a tonne.

The CIF price of crude sunflower oil was \$1,420 a tonne in February 2026 against \$1,216 a tonne in February 2025.

The CIF price of CPO was \$1,254 a tonne in February 2026 (\$1,197 a tonne in February 2025). Crude soybean oil price was \$1,254 a tonne in February 2026 (\$1,156 a tonne).

He said the rupee depreciated by over 4.2 per cent in the past year, a cause of concern to Indian importers/refiners.

SHIPMENTS UP

Meanwhile, SEA data showed a 6.82 per cent increase in the import of edible oils during the first four months of the oil year 2025-26 (November-October).

India imported 52.18 lakh tonnes (lt) of edible oil during November-February of the oil year 2025-26 against 8.85 lt in the corresponding period of the previous oil year.



Vedanta Aluminium launches honey FPC Vedamrit Jibika

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Vedanta Aluminium, through its corporate social responsibility (CSR) initiative, has launched Vedamrit Jibika Farmer Producer Company in eastern India.

In the first phase, bee boxes have been distributed to more than 500 farmers, following capacity building training.

A media statement said each honeybee box is expected to provide participating farmers an additional annual income of approximately ₹16,000.

The farmer producer organisation (FPO) is set to produce 5,000 litres of honey by April 2026, with a scale up plan to reach 20,000 litres every year.

This growth is expected to generate revenue of around ₹1 crore, securing the long-

term viability of the FPO, the statement said.

As part of the launch, Vedanta Aluminium unveiled a structured bilingual training module in Odia and English to deepen technical proficiency among farmers associated with the FPO.

HIGHER INCOME
The initiative is set to transform rural incomes in Jharsuguda by equipping farmers with scientific beekeeping practices, modern production techniques and assured

Storage in 35% of key reservoirs down below 50 per cent of capacity

Our Bureau
Chennai

Storage in at least 35 per cent of India's major 166 reservoirs dropped below 50 per cent of the capacity even as the overall level dropped below 55 per cent, per data from Central Water Commission (CWC).

The CWC said in its weekly bulletin on Thursday that the level dropped to 54 per cent of the 183.565 billion cubic BCM of the capacity at 98.913 BCM. The level dropped below 50 per cent of capacity in the northern and southern regions, while the highest storage — in the western region — was 64 per cent. In the southern region, where the level is lower than a year ago, storage in the 47

reservoirs was 44 per cent (46 per cent last year) at 24.379 BCM of the 55.288 BCM capacity. The level was 50 per cent in Tamil Nadu, 46 per cent in Kerala, 41 per cent in Karnataka and 51 per cent in Andhra Pradesh. In Telangana, it was 37 per cent.

The level in the 11 reservoirs of the northern region was 48.16 per cent of the 19.836 BCM capacity at 9.554 BCM. The 27 reservoirs of the eastern region were filled to 52 per cent of the 21.759 BCM capacity at 11.386 BCM. In the western region's 53 reservoirs, the level was 64 per cent of 24.451 BCM of the 38.094 BCM capacity. Storage in the 28 reservoirs of the central region was 60 per cent of the 48.588 BCM capacity at 29.143 BCM.

QUICKLY.

AP govt urges Capgemini to set up GCC in Vizag



Hyderabad: Andhra Pradesh Minister for Education, IT and Electronics Nara Lokesh appealed to Capgemini Chief Executive Officer Aiman Ezzat to set up a development centre and a Global Capability Centre (GCC) during a meeting in Visakhapatnam. He also encouraged the company to set up service centres for cloud services and BPM verticals. Stating that the coastal city is emerging as a global data centre hub, the Minister said that the city will have a greenfield international airport, ensuring global connectivity. **OUR BUREAU**

Turkish firms removed from metro projects: Govt

UNANSWERED QUESTIONS. Maharashtra Metro and the Centre did not respond to specific queries on the companies’ involvement in projects

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

Ten months after the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) directed the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MHUA) to scrap metro rail contracts involving Turkish companies over security concerns tied to that country’s support to Pakistan during Operation Sindoor, work on several metro projects across India continues. A June 6, 2025, an official memorandum to the MHUA called for “review of the metro projects and revoke/cancel any form of contract/agreement involving Turkish companies ASIS Elektronik Ve Billiseri Sistemleri and Gulemak Agir Sanayi Insant Ve Taahhut AS JV on grounds of national security”.

As a follow-up, the Ministry communicated its decision to review and cancel metro contracts involving the firms to the concerned States and sought action taken reports. The companies came under scrutiny over sabotage and espionage risks, with potential national security implications. ASIS Elektronik was awarded the Pune Metro contract in 2020, while the deal for ‘automated fare collection system’ in the Bhopal and Indore metro rail projects were awarded in 2022. The company also got work for the Mumbai Metro Rail Corporation in 2022, correspondence between the two Ministries, accessed by *businessline*, revealed. Gulermak Agir was engaged for other metro rail project works at Bhopal and



ESPIONAGE RISKS. The two companies under scrutiny are ASIS Elektronik Ve Billiseri Sistemleri and Gulemak Agir Sanayi Insant Ve Taahhut AS JV **PTI**

Indore as well. “In light of the overt support given by Turkey to Pakistan during Operation Sindoor, involvement of Turkish entities in projects of strategic significance has been reviewed considering the security implications, including espionage risk. These pose grave threats to national security,”

the MHA wrote to the Secretary, MHUA, on June 6.

NO ANSWERS In response to a *businessline* questionnaire, the MHUA said: “The Bhopal and Indore metro projects, which are under implementation, have already removed Asis.” But the Ministry was silent on

the electrical works Gulemak Agir Sanayi did for the Bhopal and Indore metro projects. Despite repeated queries, the Ministry ignored specific questions regarding whether the Mumbai and Pune metro projects were reviewed or if action was taken. Maharashtra Metro Rail Corporation MD Ashwini Bhide did not respond to repeated calls and queries sent on WhatsApp about the two metro contracts awarded to the Turkish company. The Madhya Pradesh government, through a letter on July 28, 2025, had sought the advice of the MHA on “continuance of contract with these Turkish companies in view of the present security scenario”. To that, the MHA suggested review and revoke/cancel any form of contract/agreements involving the

two Turkish companies in metro projects on “the ground of national security”. Sources said the MP Metro Rail Corporation had allegedly not taken any action on electrical work related projects for the Bhopal and Indore metros. Gulermak had signed a contract with Kalpataru Power Transmission Ltd for electrical work for the Bhopal project in September 2022. Similarly, work was awarded to the same joint venture in July for electrical work for the Indore metro project. The firm also got a contract for Bhopal Metro tunnel on March 3, 2024, official documents showed. The MHUA ignored queries regarding proposed actions against MPMRCL for non-compliance and its impact on national security.

House Panel urges smart meter push

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

A parliamentary panel has urged the Power Ministry to expedite the installation of smart meters in a structured and time-bound manner. The Eleventh Report of the Committee on ‘Demands for Grants (2026-27) of the Ministry of Power’ was tabled in Parliament on Thursday. It said since the pace of installation of smart meters across the country was far below the envisaged targets, the Ministry should take steps to accelerate the process, with clearly defined State-wise and utility-wise milestones. It noted that the government had set a target of installation of 25 crore smart meters in the country by March 2025, against which only 5.83 crore smart meters had been installed till February 15, 2026.

Hospitality sector to get 20% of average monthly commercial LPG requirement

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri told Parliament on Thursday that restaurants will get 20 per cent of the average monthly requirement of LPG. He assured that alternative sources are being tapped to address the shortage. Puri said extensive meetings had been held with State civil supply departments and restaurant associations across the country. A committee set up to monitor developments on the LPG front had assessed genuine need by geography and sector to ensure available commercial volume reaches genuine users first. “In a major decision, 20 per cent of the average

monthly commercial LPG requirement will be allocated from today by OMCs, in coordination with the State governments so that there is no hoarding or black marketing,” he said. To ease pressure on LPG and gas channels, kerosene is now available through retail outlets and PDS channels. Also, fuel oil is being made available for industrial and commercial consumers. “The Environment Ministry has advised State Pollution Control Boards to permit, for the duration of this crisis period, the use of biomass, RDF pellets, and kerosene/coal as alternative fuels for the hospitality and restaurant segment for one month, which would enable a wider range of establishments to switch and free up LPG for priority con-



Hardeep Singh Puri in Lok Sabha **SANSAD TV/ANI VIDEO GRAB**

sumers,” he said. He informed that around 60 per cent of LPG requirement was being met through import from Qatar, UAE, Saudi Arabia, and Kuwait. The rest is being produced domestically. “Procurement has now been actively diversified, with cargoes being se-

cured from the US, Norway, Canada, Algeria and Russia, in addition to available Gulf sources,” he said. In the last 5 days, LPG production had been increased by 28 per cent through refinery directives, and further procurement is actively underway.

SPECIAL DISCUSSION Puri was responding to a special discussion on LPG based on notice given by Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi, who said the US-Israel and Iran war is going to have far-reaching consequences. He wondered why a nation the size of India would allow any other nation, the President of another nation, to give permission to buy Russian oil. “I have figured the puzzle out. And the puzzle is about compromise,” Gandhi said.

Murmu calls for greater role for women in framing agri-food sector policies

Our Bureau
New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu on Thursday suggested providing targeted support for women farmers on issues relating to land titles, access to technical knowledge and institutional finance. She also asked for a greater role for women engaged in the agri-food sector, particularly in policy formation, decision-making and leadership positions. Inaugurating a three-day ‘Global Conference on Women in Agri-Food Systems’, she said case studies on successful women in agriculture should be published widely to ensure awareness. Highlighting that the government had conferred Padma Shri awards on women farmers of



GENDER-INCLUSIVE. President Droupadi Murmu addressing the inaugural session of the ‘Global Conference on the Role of Women in Agri-Food Systems’ in New Delhi **ANI**

Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Odisha and Bihar, she said the next generation should draw inspiration from these trailblazers to contribute meaningfully to the farm sector. “Larger participation of women at all levels in the sector will promote gender-inclusive agricultural

growth,” Murmu said. She called for collective action on closing the gender gap and welcomed the UN’s declaration of 2026 as the ‘International Year of Women Farmers’. Murmu also highlighted Sarlaben, an AI-powered initiative inspired by the government’s livestock care vis-

ion, as an example of how artificial intelligence is opening new possibilities for women farmers. She also shared a number of government initiatives, including Jan Dhan Yojana, during the past decade, which were aimed at empowering women in agriculture. The JDY has 56 per cent share of women in the 570 million bank accounts, while they have 68 per cent share in Mudra loans. Similarly, over 10 crore rural households and 90 lakh self-help groups (SHGs) had been mobilised under the largest women-led community initiative National Rural Livelihood Mission (NRLM), where over 4.6 crore women farmers have received support for adopting improved farming practices.

War risk surcharges hit exporters as Gulf freight rates surge

Radheshyam Jadhav
Pune

The sharp spike in freight rates following the escalation of West Asia conflict has severely impacted Indian exporters, particularly small and medium exporters to Gulf markets. Exporters from Maharashtra said previously, freight rates to Dubai were about \$800 per container, while shipments to Kuwait and Qatar cost around \$1,300. However, soon after the war began, shipping lines imposed a war risk surcharge of about \$3,200 per container, even on cargo that had already been loaded or was already at sea.

COST RECOVERY According to exporters, the surcharge was also applied to containers that had already



TIGHT SPOT. Surcharge was also applied to containers that had already reached Gulf ports but had not yet been discharged

reached Gulf ports but had not yet been discharged. An exporter from Nashik said, “There is no way to recover this cost from buyers in the Gulf.” Exporters said consignments cannot be released unless the surcharge is paid, forcing them to absorb the additional cost. Traders in Nashik said several exporters had 10-15 containers affected, resulting in losses running into ₹40-50 lakh in some cases.

Shipping disruptions further compounded the crisis. Some vessels reportedly turned back due to security concerns, with exporters claiming that shipping lines charged freight for both the outbound and return journeys. Agricultural exports are among the worst affected. Exporters said nearly 500 containers of bananas were planned for shipment but are now stranded.

IITM Pravartak, SRIT to offer secure database platform

Our Bureau
Chennai

IITM Pravartak Technologies has announced a collaboration with SRIT, a systems integration services provider, to deploy ShaktiDB across enterprises. ShaktiDB is an indigenously developed database platform tailored for government and highly regulated sectors. It is designed for mission-critical deployments, offering better data sovereignty and security at a lower cost. **GOVT FUNDING** Through this collaboration, SRIT will implement and scale deployments of ShaktiDB across real enterprise environments. The initiative has been undertaken with funding from the Ministry of Electronics and IT, Government of India. “This collaboration rep-



resents a strategic step toward accelerating indigenous technology adoption and enabling institutions to confidently transition to secure, enterprise-grade platforms developed in India, for India,” Shankar Raman, CEO, IITM Pravartak, said. “By working closely with IITM Pravartak, we are not only embracing innovation but also contributing to the larger vision of technological self-reliance and future-ready digital infrastructure in the country,” said Madhu Nambiar, Chairman, SRIT.

Grew Energy to bring in Chinese engineers to set up solar cell unit

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Gujarat-based Grew Energy Pvt Ltd is bringing in around 40 engineers from China to help install and commission its upcoming solar cell manufacturing plant in Madhya Pradesh. “Because of the current geopolitical situation it is difficult to have direct tie-ups with Chinese companies. However, equipment manufacturers in China transfer the know-how to us and we will also provide the engineers who will come and set up the plant,” Vinay Thadani, Director and CEO of Grew Energy, told *businessline* in an exclusive interview. As part of the contract, the engineers from Suzhou, a key centre for solar equipment



manufacturing in China, are expected to stay in India for nearly two years to help run the machines, train local manpower and ensure production lines meet the required performance benchmarks. Grew began constructing an 8 GW solar cell manufacturing facility in April 2025 at Narmadapuram in Bhopal,

Madhya Pradesh, where it has been allotted 60 acres land. Phase-1 of the project involves building a 3 GW plant with an investment of around ₹2,000 crore, with trial runs expected to begin in April 2026. The company has also begun construction of phase-2, which will add another 5 GW at an estimated cost of ₹3,600 crore, with commissioning targeted by March 2027.

WILL REPEAT MODEL “We will repeat the same model, bring in Chinese technicians for the proposed ingot and wafer plant (in Madhya Pradesh) as well,” Thadani said. The company has already acquired 65 acres of land for the project and plans to build a 3 GW ingot and wafer facility in phase-1.

Govt ensures 80% gas allocation for GCMMF; many industries take a hit

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Dairy plants under the Gujarat Cooperative Milk Marketing Federation (GCMMF) umbrella, which produce the Amul brand of milk and milk products and rely on natural gas to power boilers and heating systems, have been granted priority supply from the government, securing 80 per cent of their daily requirement. “We have over 20 milk processing plants belonging to 12 district milk producing unions in Gujarat who are dependent on natural gas. But fortunately for us, the government has decided to give priority supply to the dairy sector and increased our quota to 80 percent of our average daily requirement,” Jayen Mehta, Managing Director, GCMMF told *businessline*.



Jayen Mehta, MD, GCMMF

“For the balance-energy needs, our boilers can switch to diesel, furnace oil, light diesel oil (LDO) or briquettes. So, there will be no disruption in our supply,” Mehta added. The move will ensure that Gujarat’s sprawling milk processing network, handling over 300 lakh litres daily from 18,600 village-level co-operatives, can continue operations without disruption, even as gas supplies tighten nationwide.

Overall allocations to other industries in Gujarat have been cut to 50% of their average daily requirements

However, not all industrial users have been as fortunate. Overall allocations to other industries in Gujarat have been cut to 50 per cent of their average daily requirements, reflecting the broader strain on natural gas and LPG supply. The Gujarat unit of the Indian Chamber of Commerce (ICC) wrote to the State government on Thursday, highlighting the critical need for uninterrupted LPG supply for pharmaceutical units manufacturing essential and life-saving medicines. Pathik Patwari, Chair of

the Gujarat Council of ICC, said, “Due to the prevailing global situation and supply disruptions, the availability of LPG cylinders has become inconsistent. As a result, the existing stock with these manufacturers is sufficient only for a few days of operations.”

PANEL FORMED Charotar Gas Sahakari Mandali Ltd, among India’s earliest city gas distribution (CGD) players from the co-operative sector, has temporarily restricted CNG sales at its 14 dispensing stations across Anand and parts of Kheda district in Gujarat. It has limited dispensing to a few hours in the morning and evening. The current supply allocated to the network — sourced via pipeline from Hazira — stands around 1.7 lakh standard cubic metres (scm) per day. Gujarat government

spokesperson and Cabinet Minister Jitu Vaghani said, “A committee has been formed under the leadership of Chief Secretary (MK Das) to coordinate supply of CNG. Large CGD companies, including state-government-owned entities like Gujarat Gas, have issued *force majeure* curtailing the supply of natural gas to important sectors like ceramics and glass manufacturing.”

TO ADVERTISE PLEASE CONTACT

Chennai : 044 - 28576300

Coimbatore : 0422 - 2212572

Madurai : 0452 - 2528497

Trichy : 0431 - 2302801

Puducherry : 0413 - 2224111

thehindu **businessline.**

DREAM PROPERTIES

MOVE IN TODAY
TO THE HIGHEST LEVEL OF LIVING

5TH FLOOR SIGNATURE PENTHOUSE

Full-Floor Residence With Private Terrace at NUNGAMBAKKAM

• Completion Certificate Received • Rs. 10 Cr. Onwards

98840 47171
www.duggar.in

DUGGAR CREDAI

